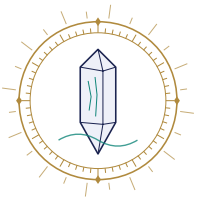

THE COMMUNION OF THE UNSENT

The Communion of the Unsent

Ikai-okuri, Theomachy, and the Ethics of Passage in Final Fantasy (1987–2024)

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異界送り

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ABSTRACT

The Communion of the Unsent

This thesis contends that Square's—from 2003, Square Enix's—*Final Fantasy*, read across its sixteen numbered entries (1987–2023) and its principal satellites (*Final Fantasy Tactics*, the *Compilation* and *Remake* of *Final Fantasy VII*, *Type-0*, the *Fabula Nova Crystallis* cycle, and *Final Fantasy XIV* through *Dawntrail*, 2024), constitutes not an anthology of discrete fantasies but a single, serially elaborated philosophical system, and that the problem organizing that system is the problem of passage: whether that which lives—persons, peoples, civilizations, gods, and finally the played world itself—may be permitted to end. Against readings that subsume the series under the Campbellian monomyth or a generic Manichaean contest of light and darkness, the study reconstructs a structuring opposition between two ontological registers, designated the *lithic* (the crystal: preservation, permanence, record, providence, return) and the *fluvial* (the stream: Lifestream, Farplane, aetherial sea; transience, transformation, release). It demonstrates that the series' antagonists—from Garland's two-thousand-year temporal loop to Sephiroth's vow never to become a memory, from Emet-Selch's reconstructed Amaurot to the archived dead of *Dawntrail*'s Living Memory—compose a *Communion of the Unsent*: a typology of figures who refuse passage and who therefore institute *necrostasis*, the government of the living by the unreleased dead, and *necro-extractivism*, the conversion of the dead into energy, labor and sovereign power.

Methodologically, the thesis joins comparative philosophical hermeneutics to procedural reading and to a transcultural genealogy that distinguishes documented influence from structural analogy. It mobilizes Japanese religious practice (*ikai-okuri*, the *goryō* cult of vengeful spirits, the *itako* medium, the *hitobashira* legend, the periodic rebuilding of the Ise shrines); Buddhist philosophy and the Kyoto School (Vasubandhu, Dōgen, Nishida, Nishitani, Watsuji); Gnostic, Neoplatonic and kenotic theology (Jonas, Plotinus, Origen, Luria, Bonhoeffer); continental philosophy (Heidegger, Nietzsche, Benjamin, Schmitt, Arendt, Ricoeur, Derrida, Camus, Whitehead); and a comparative archive of myth and speculative fiction extending from the *Enūma Eliš* and the *Ṛgveda* to Tolkien, Le Guin, Borges, Lem, Dick, Moorcock, Miyazaki, Anno and Jemisin.

Four further propositions follow. First, the series migrates from *Chaoskampf*, the archaic combat against chaos, to what is here termed *Kosmoskampf*, combat against gods of order whose providence requires the arrest of time—a trajectory culminating not in simple deicide but in a kenotic deity who consents to her own withdrawal. Second, its heroism is *psychopompic* rather than monomythic: the protagonist's vocation is to conduct passage, not to return bearing a boon. Third, its anthology form enacts a *metempsychotic seriality*, a transmigration of motifs without a transmigrating self, theorized more exactly through the Yogācāra storehouse-consciousness (*ālayavijñāna*), which proceeds "like a torrent," than through Azuma Hiroki's data-

base. Fourth, the series exhibits an *autotheomachic* structure in which the ludic apparatus of save, reload, revival and replay is disclosed as the very divinity the narrative condemns, so that the player is enjoined to perform upon their own sovereignty the deicide the heroes perform upon the gods.

The thesis concludes by formalizing these findings as an *ethics of passage*, or *fluvial finitism*, whose first philosophy is the Sending: the conviction that to let a world end well is the highest form of care for it. The title *Final Fantasy* is accordingly read not as commercial accident but as an exact philosophical formula—a fantasy *of* finality, and a fantasy that consents to *be* final.

INTRODUCTION

The Paradox of a Final Fantasy

i ◆ A Fantasy of Finality

The title is an oxymoron that has been repeated sixteen times. Sakaguchi Hironobu has offered two accounts of its origin. The first, long canonical, ties the word *final* to Square's precarious finances in 1987 and to his own resolve to abandon game development should the project fail. The second, given in later interviews, subordinates semantics to phonetics: the decisive desideratum was an abbreviation, "FF," agreeable in Japanese pronunciation; *Fighting Fantasy*, already the title of Steve Jackson and Ian Livingstone's gamebook series (1982–), was unavailable; and any word beginning with *F* would have served. This thesis neither adjudicates between these accounts nor requires either. Borges observed that every writer creates his own precursors ("Kafka and His Precursors," 1951); a long series, analogously, creates the meaning of its own name. Whatever *final* once meant in Square's Tokyo offices, it has been retroactively filled by thirty-seven years of worlds that end.

The arithmetic of the franchise compounds the paradox. A sixteenth "final" fantasy is a contradiction in terms, and the contradiction is not a marketing curiosity but the philosophical datum from which this inquiry begins. *Final Fantasy* is a seriality whose content is finitude. Each numbered entry builds a cosmos, brings it to the brink of dissolution, and closes; the next begins again with a new world and a handful of migrating names. The series therefore poses at the level of its form the question its narratives pose at the level of content: how can something end and continue at once, and what, in that continuation, is permitted to persist?

The contrast with the founding theory of fantasy in English is instructive. In "On Fairy-Stories" (1947), Tolkien named the genre's highest function *Consolation* and its signature turn the *eucatastrophe*, the sudden joyous reversal that denies "universal final defeat." The Japanese series,

by name, foregrounds not consolation but finality. Its characteristic endings—Tidus dissolving amid pyreflies, Noctis enthroned in death, Midgar overgrown five centuries after its catastrophe, Valisthea emptied of magic—are consolations that pass *through* ending rather than around it. The question pursued here is whether a fantasy can console by ending, and what metaphysics, ethics and politics such a consolation presupposes.

ii ◆ Thesis

The central claim is that the Sending—*ikai-okuri* (異界送り), the rite in *Final Fantasy X* by which a summoner releases the dead into the Farplane—is not merely one ritual among the series' invented customs but the implicit first philosophy of the whole. Every major structure in the series can be read as an elaboration of, or a resistance to, the act of letting pass. Seven subsidiary theses articulate the claim, each developed in a chapter and each introducing a concept proposed here.

The first concerns ontology: the series is organized by an opposition between the *lithic* and the *fluvial*, crystal and stream, in which the crystal is progressively revealed to be nothing other than the stream arrested (Chapter One). The second concerns antagonism: the series' villains form a *Communion of the Unsent*, a typology of refused passage whose political form is *necrostasis*, the rule of the living by the unreleased dead (Chapter Two). The third concerns political economy: the material base of necrostasis is *necro-extractivism*, the harvesting of the dead—souls, Mist, aether, mako—as energy and labor, administered by empires behind whose thrones stand gods (Chapters Three and Four). The fourth concerns personhood: the series' treatment of memory and mortality yields a *promissory* theory of the self and a *relational* theory of death, corrective of Locke and of Heidegger alike (Chapters Five and Six). The fifth concerns theology: the series moves from *Chaoskampf* to *Kosmoskampf*, from war against chaos to war against providential order, and terminates in the image of a god who sends herself (Chapter Seven). The sixth concerns heroism: the protagonist is a *psychopomp*, an escort of souls, rather than a Campbellian hero of return (Chapter Eight). The seventh concerns form: the series is *autotheomachic*, enlisting the player to slay the figure of the player, and *metempsychotic*, transmitting motifs across worlds without a transmigrating self (Chapters Nine and Ten). The synthesis—*fluvial finitism*, or the ethics of passage—holds that to let a world end well is the highest form of care for it.

iii ◆ State of the Field

Scholarship on *Final Fantasy* has been abundant but atomized. Game studies, in its formative debate between ludological and narratological positions (Murray 1997; Aarseth 1997; Frasca 2003; Jenkins 2004; Juul 2005), treated Japanese role-playing games chiefly as test cases for the relation between rule and story; subsequent work on procedural rhetoric (Bogost 2007), gamic action (Galloway 2006) and the ethics of play (Sicart 2009) supplies tools this thesis uses but has rarely applied them to the series as a whole. Japanese media theory has furnished powerful accounts of

serial consumption—Ōtsuka Eiji's "narrative consumption," with its Kabuki-derived dyad of *sekai* (world) and *shukō* (variation) (1989), and Azuma Hiroki's "database animals" (2001)—together with Susan Napier's typology of the apocalyptic, elegiac and festival modes of anime (2005), Iwabuchi Kōichi's analysis of the culturally "odorless" (*mukokuseki*) export (2002), and studies of Japanese games as cultural texts (Consalvo 2016; Hutchinson 2019). Philosophical engagement with the series as such has largely taken the form of essay collections addressed to general readers (Blahuta and Beaulieu 2009), valuable for individual insights but structurally committed to entry-by-entry treatment. A substantial para-academic literature—developer commentary in the *Ultimania* guides, retrospective interviews, monographs by fan-scholars—is indispensable for production history but seldom philosophically synthetic.

Three lacunae follow. The first is *atomization*: entries are read singly, so that recurring structures appear as coincidences rather than as a system. The second is *Westernization*: philosophical readings import existentialist or Christian frames while neglecting the Japanese religious practices—mortuary rites, the pacification of vengeful spirits, shamanic mediumship, shrine renewal—that supply the series' deep grammar. The third is *form-blindness*: narrative is read in abstraction from the ludic apparatus, although the apparatus of saving, reviving and replaying is the most persistent argument the series makes. This thesis addresses all three.

iv ◆ Method: Genealogy, Analogy, Procedure

The method is threefold. A *comparative philosophical hermeneutics*, in Gadamer's sense (1960), seeks a fusion of horizons between Japanese and Euro-American traditions, treating neither as the master code of the other. A *procedural reading* treats mechanics—the Phoenix Down, the save crystal, the status effect—as propositions, following Bogost's claim that rules make arguments. A *transcultural genealogy* distinguishes three grades of relation, which the text marks explicitly: the *documented* (creators' statements; explicit borrowings, as of names from mythology, of monsters from *Dungeons & Dragons*, or of Biggs and Wedge from *Star Wars*; the channel opened by Amano Yoshitaka's illustrations for the Japanese editions of Michael Moorcock's Elric saga); the *demonstrable* (shared vocabularies, such as the Gnostic "aeon" introduced by the English localization of *Final Fantasy X*); and the *analogical* (structural homologies asserted without any claim of influence, such as that between *Dawntrail* and Le Guin's *The Other Wind*). The analogical grade carries the heaviest interpretive weight and the lightest historical claim; confusing the two is the commonest vice of thematic criticism, and the distinction is maintained throughout.

Localization is treated as interpretation. The English texts of Ted Woolsey (*IV*, *VI*), Alexander O. Smith (*X*, *XII*) and Michael-Christopher Koji Fox (*XIV*, *XVI*) are hermeneutic acts in their own right; where Japanese and English diverge in philosophically material ways, both are treated as primary and the divergence is itself read.

v ◆ Corpus and Conventions

The corpus comprises the numbered entries from *Final Fantasy* (1987) to *Final Fantasy XVI* (2023), including *X-2* (2003), *XIII-2* (2011) and *Lightning Returns* (2013); *Final Fantasy Tactics* (1997); *Final Fantasy Type-0* (2011); the *Compilation of Final Fantasy VII*, including *Advent Children* (2005) and *Crisis Core* (2007), together with *Final Fantasy VII Remake* (2020) and *Rebirth* (2024); and *Final Fantasy XIV* from its 2010 launch and 2013 relaunch as *A Realm Reborn* through *Dawntrail* (2024). The corpus closes in 2024; later material lies outside its scope, a limitation that bears directly on the unresolved conclusion of the *Remake* project. Japanese personal names appear in Japanese order, family name first; romanization follows modified Hepburn; entries are abbreviated *FF I* to *FF XVI*; citations follow author–date form, and ludic sources are cited by title and year of first Japanese release.

vi ◆ Plan of the Work

Part One, *Ontologies*, establishes the lithic–fluvial opposition (Chapter One) and the typology of the Unsent (Chapter Two). Part Two, *Economies and Polities*, analyzes necro-extractivism (Chapter Three) and the series' political theology of empire, slavery and revolt (Chapter Four). Part Three, *Persons*, treats memory and identity (Chapter Five) and death and finitude (Chapter Six). Part Four, *Gods and Forms*, traces the passage from *Chaoskampf* to *Kosmoskampf* (Chapter Seven), the psychopompic structure of heroism (Chapter Eight) and the autotheomachic relation between apparatus and player (Chapter Nine). Part Five, *Synthesis*, formalizes the ethics of passage, tests it against objections and reads the series' title as its last word (Chapter Ten).

PART ONE

Ontologies

CHAPTER ONE
The Lithic and the Fluvial

CHAPTER TWO
The Communion of the Unsent

CHAPTER ONE

The Lithic and the Fluvial

Crystal Cosmology and the Stream of Souls

The cosmology of *Final Fantasy* is built from two substances, crystal and current, and the series' philosophical history is the history of their revaluation. Across thirty-seven years the crystal passes from guarantor of cosmic balance to instrument of cosmic theft, while the stream passes from background to sacrament. This chapter reconstructs that revaluation and argues that its decisive discovery, made explicit in *FF VII*, is that the lithic is not the fluvial's opposite but its arrest.

1.1 ◆ The Crystal as Cosmological Constant

In *FF I* (1987) the vitality of the world depends on four elemental crystals (rendered "ORBs" in the North American release), darkened by four Fiends who correspond to earth, fire, water and wind. The tetrad is Empedoclean—the four "roots" (*rhizōmata*) of fragment DK B6—and it also recalls, by subtraction, the *godai* (五大) of esoteric Buddhism, the five great elements of earth, water, fire, wind and void (*kū*, 空). The fifth element is absent from the first game; it returns five years later as the series' first metaphysical horror. The Warriors of Light restore light to the crystals, and the good is defined restoratively, as the re-establishment of an original order. Yet a fissure is already visible. The final antagonist, Chaos, is produced by a temporal loop in which the knight Garland, sent two thousand years into the past, becomes the demon who will one day send him back. At its very origin the series identifies evil with a closed circle of time.

FF III (1990) refines this cosmology into a metaphysics of equilibrium. Its backstory concerns not a flood of darkness but a flood of *light*, a catastrophe averted a millennium earlier by Warriors of Darkness; its antagonist, the Cloud of Darkness, feeds upon imbalance as such. Light is not the good; balance is. The structure is recognizably Daoist—the *Daodejing* holds that being

and non-being generate one another (ch. 2) and that all things carry yin and embrace yang (ch. 42)—and it is also Moorcockian, since Michael Moorcock's Eternal Champion cycle, from the Elric stories of 1961 onward, organizes its multiverse around a Cosmic Balance between Law and Chaos. The latter relation is documented rather than merely analogical: Amano Yoshitaka, whose watercolors defined the early series, had illustrated the Japanese editions of Moorcock. The series' first cosmology is thus neither Manichaean nor Christian but equilibrial.

FF IV (1991) and *FF V* (1992) begin the crystal's demotion. In *IV* the crystals become geopolitical resources seized by the Kingdom of Baron: the cosmic constant becomes a strategic asset. In *V* the crystals are mechanically amplified to increase their yield and shatter under the strain, and the world's elements fail in sequence—the series' first explicit critique of extraction. With the crystals broken, the fifth element returns. Exdeath seeks the power of the Void, in Japanese simply 無 (*mu*), "nothingness," which devours whatever it touches. The term is philosophically loaded. Heidegger had argued that the Nothing is no mere negation but itself "nihilates" (*Das Nichts selbst nichtet*, 1929); Nishida Kitarō had made absolute nothingness (絶対無, *zettai mu*) the ground of his philosophy; Nāgārjuna had identified emptiness (*śūnyatā*) with dependent origination itself (*Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* 24.18). *FF V* stages *mu* not as liberating emptiness but as consuming nihility—what Nishitani Keiji would call relative nothingness (虚無, *kyomu*), the abyss that must be passed through rather than embraced (1961). The distinction proves decisive in Chapter Six.

1.2 ◆ A Phenomenology of the Crystal

The crystal is an image before it is an object, and its imaginative properties are three. It is *transparent*: nothing is hidden, everything is legible. It is *rigid*: it does not grow except by accretion. And it is *periodic*: crystallography defines it by the translational repetition of a unit cell, so that a crystal is, in the most literal sense available to matter, the eternal return of the same in space. A crystal can only reproduce its pattern. It is the mineral form of a world that has completed itself.

The image has a long Western career. Plato built the elements from regular solids (*Timaeus* 53c–56c); Aristotelian–Ptolemaic cosmology nested the planets in crystalline spheres; the Apocalypse sets "a sea of glass like unto crystal" before the throne (Rev. 4:6) and describes the New Jerusalem as "clear as crystal" (Rev. 21:11), so that the eschaton itself is crystalline. Modernism secularized the vision: Paul Scheerbart's *Glasarchitektur* (1914) and Bruno Taut's *Alpine Architektur* (1919) imagined crystal cities as the architecture of a spiritually redeemed humanity, a lineage Rosemarie Haag Bletter has traced as the history of the crystal metaphor (1981). The counter-tradition is as old. Dostoevsky's Underground Man refuses the Crystal Palace of Chernyshevsky's rationalist utopia because within it human beings would become piano keys, their freedom abolished by the perfection of order (*Notes from Underground*, 1864); Zamyatin's glass city in *We* (written 1920–21) extends the critique to the totalitarian state; Sloterdijk reads the Crystal Palace as the figure of capitalism's climate-controlled world interior (2005). For this tradition, utopia as completion is indistinguishable from death.

The crystal also answers Faust's wager. Goethe's Faust stakes his soul on the condition that he never say to the passing moment, *Verweile doch! du bist so schön!*—"Stay, you are so beautiful!" (*Faust I*, 1808, l. 1700). The crystal is that wish granted: the moment arrested, made hard and luminous and permanent. The series' central intuition is that the granted wish is a damnation.

1.3 ◆ The Ludic Crystal

The crystal is also the player's instrument. Across the series the save point—the place where the state of the world is arrested, recorded and made recoverable—has taken crystalline or crystal-adjacent form: the save spheres of *FF X* (2001), the save crystals of *FF XII* (2006), and the aetherytes of *FF XIV*, crystal monoliths to which the player may teleport by a general action named, with unwitting precision, *Return*. *FF X*'s choice is the most telling, since the sphere is also the medium in which Spira records the memories of the dead: saving the game and preserving a ghost are the same technical act. The crystal is the interface through which the player exercises sovereignty over time—the power to arrest, to record, to resume. It is where the player becomes a god. Chapter Nine returns to this.

1.4 ◆ The Fluvial Turn

FF VII (1997) introduces the series' second substance in its definitive form. The Lifestream (ライフストリーム) is the spiritual energy of the Planet: souls flow into it at death, mingle, and return to new life. The elder Bugenhagen of Cosmo Canyon teaches this "Study of Planet Life" as a planetary ethics. The Shinra Electric Power Company pumps the Lifestream from the earth, refines it as mako and burns it for electricity; condensed further, mako crystallizes into *materia*, the orbs through which characters cast magic, and materia holds the knowledge of the Ancients. Here lies the series' pivotal discovery. Materia—Latin for matter, Aristotle's *hylē*—is the stream congealed. The lithic is not opposed to the fluvial from outside; it is the fluvial arrested. To cast a spell is to consume condensed memory of the dead. Retroactively, every crystal of the earlier games becomes legible as a mineralized river of souls.

The Lifestream condenses several genealogies, most of them analogical. Heraclitus held that upon those who step into the same rivers, other and still other waters flow (DK B12). Kamo no Chōmei opened the *Hōjōki* (1212) with the observation, here newly translated, that "the current of the flowing river never fails, and yet the water is never the same water." Bergson's *élan vital* (1907) is life as a current passing through matter; Lovelock's Gaia (1979) is the planet as a self-regulating whole; Teilhard de Chardin's noosphere (1955) is a planetary envelope of thought. The Lifestream is a noosphere that is also a necrosphere: it stores knowledge because it stores the dead. Most precisely, the Yogācāra storehouse-consciousness, the *ālayavijñāna*, which carries the seeds of past action from life to life without constituting a self, is said in Vasubandhu's *Triṃśikā* (v. 4) to proceed like a torrent. At the level of documented genealogy, Sakaguchi has linked the

preoccupation with "life" in *FF VII* to the death of his mother during the development of *FF III*. The Lifestream is, at its origin, a work of mourning.

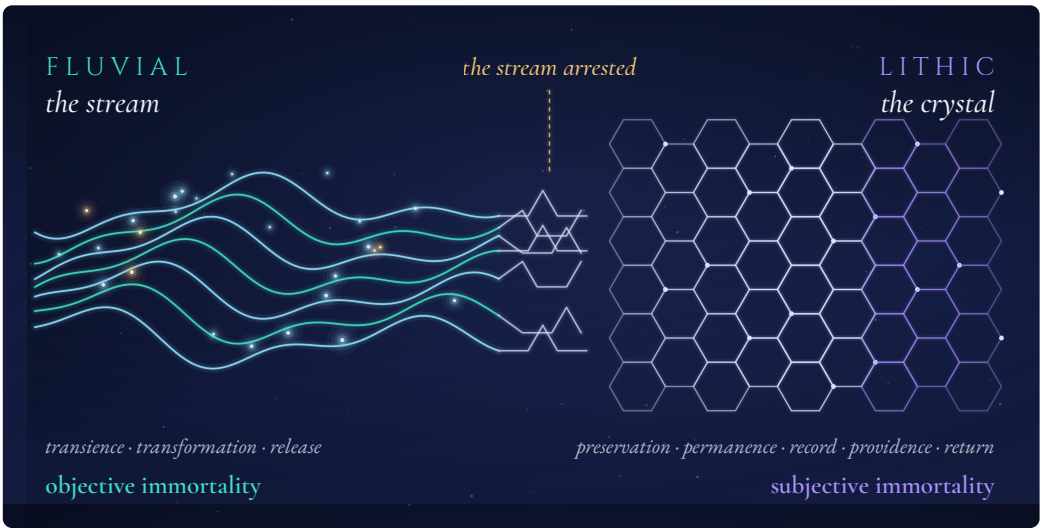


FIGURE 1 *The two substances. The lithic seeks subjective immortality, the fluvial grants objective immortality, and the crystal is the stream arrested (§§1.4–1.6).*

Subsequent entries vary the fluvial. *FF IX* (2000) interposes a tree. The Iifa Tree, a Yggdrasil-like world-ash, intercepts the souls of Gaia and emits them as Mist, a hierarchy imposed upon a flow so that the souls may be diverted toward the assimilation of another world; in the terms of Deleuze and Guattari (1980), the arborescent captures the rhizomatic. Yet *IX* also performs the series' most generous reconciliation of its two substances, for at the end of Memoria lies the primordial Crystal from which all life issued: the crystal re-signified as spring rather than store. *FF X* (2001) atomizes the stream into pyreflies (幻光虫, *genkōchū*), luminous motes released by the dying, which recall the *hitodama* soul-fires of Japanese folklore and the fireflies the same culture associates with the dead, most memorably in Takahata Isao's *Grave of the Fireflies* (1988); the Farplane (異界, *ikai*, "the other world") is their destination. *FF XIV* elaborates an aetherial sea to which souls return to be cleansed and reborn, and a cosmogony in which a single world was sundered into fourteen—a Plotinian procession (*proodos*) from unity into multiplicity, which its antagonists seek to reverse by a forced return (*epistrophē*) (Chapters Two and Seven).

1.5 ◆ Late-Lithic Hypertrophy

From the late 2000s the crystal swells into pathology. In *FF XIII* (2009) the reward for a completed Focus is crystal stasis, a sleep that is neither life nor death; at the climax Fang and Vanille crystallize into the pillar that holds the falling world of Cocoon aloft, an image that rehearses the *hitobashira* (人柱), the human pillar immured in the foundations of castles and bridges in Japanese legend. In *Type-0* (2011) the national crystals of Orience erase from the living the memory of

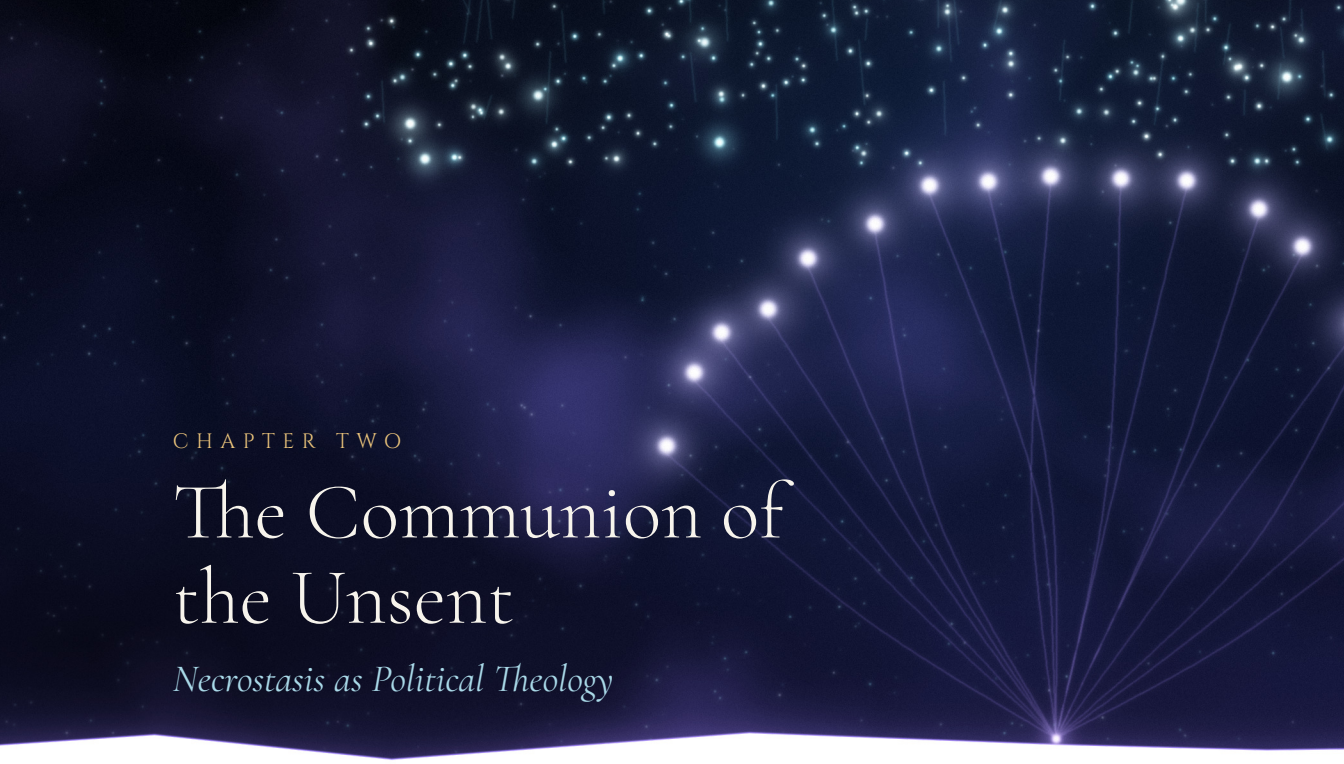
the dead (Chapter Five). In *FF XV* (2016) the Crystal of Lucis and its Ring consume the life of the king who wields their power. In *FF XVI* (2023) the Mothercrystals draw aether from the land, leaving behind the spreading deadness called the Blight, and the protagonist's project is to destroy them all. The arc completes a Nietzschean revaluation of values: the heart of the world in 1987 is its tumor in 2023.

	ENTRY	FUNCTION OF THE CRYSTAL	RELATION TO LIFE	DISPOSITION AT THE END
	FF I (1987)	Elemental heart of the world	Sustains	Restored
	FF III (1990)	Fulcrum of light–dark balance	Sustains through equilibrium	Balance restored
	FF IV (1991)	Strategic resource seized by empire	Object of acquisition	Recovered, contested
	FF V (1992)	Energy source amplified to exhaustion	Depleted by extraction	Shattered
	FF VII (1997)	Materia: condensed Lifestream	Arrested souls and knowledge	Consumed in use
	FF IX (2000)	Primordial Crystal as source of life	Fount of the stream	Reaffirmed as origin
	FF XII (2006)	Nethicite: sink of Mist, instrument of the gods	Annihilating	Sun-Cryst shattered
	FF XIII (2009)	Crystal stasis; pillar of Cocoon	Neither life nor death	Persists as monument
	Type-0 (2011)	National patron that erases the dead	Amnesia	Forgetting lifted
	FF XV (2016)	Crystal of Lucis and the Ring	Parasitic on sovereign life	Fulfilled by the king's death
	FF XVI (2023)	Mothercrystals drawing aether	Necrotic (the Blight)	Destroyed

TABLE 1. *The revaluation of the crystal.*

1.6 ◆ Toward a Dialectic: Perpetual Perishing

The opposition is not moral but temporal. Whitehead, borrowing Locke's phrase, described time as "perpetual perishing" and argued that each actual occasion, upon completing itself, perishes and attains *objective immortality*: it persists not as itself but as a datum felt by the occasions that succeed it (*Process and Reality*, 1929). His formula for creativity—"the many become one, and are increased by one"—describes the Lifestream with uncanny exactness. The distinction supplies this thesis with its first instrument. The lithic seeks *subjective* immortality: to remain as oneself, unchanged, retrievable. The fluvial grants *objective* immortality: to persist as what is received by others. The Unsent of the next chapter are partisans of the former; the senders are custodians of the latter. Every crystal in the series was once a stream, and the series' ethics, as later chapters show, consists in remembering this.



CHAPTER TWO

The Communion of the Unsent

Necrostasis as Political Theology

Every principal antagonist in the series is, in one modality or another, a being that refuses to pass. This chapter names that collectivity the *Communion of the Unsent*, derives its grammar from the Japanese mortuary and spirit-pacification practices that *FF X* renders explicit, and defines its political form as *necrostasis*.

2.1 ◆ Ikai-okuri: The Rite and Its Grammar

In *FF X* the dead who are not ritually released linger among the living as the Unsent. The summoner's Sending (異界送り, *ikai-okuri*), a dance performed upon water, lifts the pyreflies of the dead into the Farplane; the dead who envy or resent the living, left unsent, become fiends. Spira's ecology of the dead thereby reproduces with precision the logic of the *goryō* (御霊) cult of Heian Japan, according to which those who died aggrieved—exiled ministers, disgraced princes—returned as vengeful spirits to visit plague, fire and famine upon the capital unless pacified. The earliest officially recorded *goryō-e* (御霊会), a festival of pacification, was held at the Shinsen'en garden in 863. The most celebrated case, that of the minister Sugawara no Michizane (845–903), who died in exile and whose spirit was blamed for a series of calamities, was resolved by deifying him as Tenjin and enshrining him at Kitano (947). Pacification by deification: the dangerous dead are made gods so that they protect rather than harm. This is precisely Spira's theology. Its aeons are called forth from the Fayth, persons whose souls were sealed into statues; its supreme power, Yu Yevon, is the persisting will of a dead summoner; its peace is purchased by converting the dead into divine engines. The Sending belongs instead to the older and gentler stratum of *chinkon* (鎮魂), the settling of souls, and to its seasonal forms—the summer festival of Obon, at

whose close lanterns are floated downstream (*tōrō nagashi*) to carry the visiting dead back to the other world. The Sending does not deify; it releases.

2.2 ◆ The Roll of the Unsent

Read in sequence, the series' antagonists compose a single typology. In *FF I*, Garland purchases endless existence through a temporal loop. In *FF II* (1988), the Emperor of Palamecia, slain, returns from Hell as its sovereign—the series' first literal revenant. In *FF III*, the sorcerer Xande, bequeathed mortality by his master, seeks to arrest time rather than accept it (Chapter Six). In *FF IV*, the Lunarian Zemus dies and his hatred survives him as Zeromus—affect without a subject, the purest image of refused passage. In *FF V*, Exdeath is born from malign spirits sealed within a tree: the demon is the product of a failed sending, the dead imprisoned rather than released. In *FF VI* (1994), Kefka inverts the type: unable to bear that what is made will be unmade, he resolves to unmake everything. In *FF VII*, Sephiroth returns through the Lifestream and, in *Advent Children* (2005), pronounces the credo of the entire Communion: "I will never be a memory." In *FF VIII* (1999), the sorceress Ultimecia seeks to compress past, present and future into a single moment in which she alone exists. In *FF IX*, Kuja, who learns that his creator built him with a limited lifespan, would rather destroy the world than die alone. In *FF X*, Spira's Grand Maester Mika, the summoner Seymour and the ancient Yunalesca are all Unsent, and the world's supreme power is a dead man's dream. In *FF XII*, the immortal Occuria administer history from outside it. In *FF XIII*, the fal'Cie would slaughter Cocoon's population to summon back their departed Maker; in *XIII-2*, Caius Ballad would kill the goddess of death to spare the seeress Yeul her endless deaths; in *Lightning Returns*, the god Bhunivelze would remake the world with souls purged of the "chaos" of the heart. In *FF XIV*, the Ascian Emet-Selch reconstructs his drowned capital, Amaurot, from memory; Meteion, in *Endwalker* (2021), carries the despair of dead civilizations across the cosmos; Queen Sphene, in *Dawntrail* (2024), preserves her people's dead as the Endless of Living Memory. In *FF XV*, Ardyn Izunia is cursed with deathlessness and erased from history. In *FF XVI*, Ultima, survivor of a dying race, has engineered humanity as the instrument of his kind's continuation.

2.3 ◆ A Typology of Refused Passage

Five modalities organize the Communion. The *temporal* Unsent (Garland, Ultimecia, Caius) attack time itself, by the loop or by compression; they are heretics against succession. The *somatic* Unsent (the Emperor, Xande, Sephiroth, Kuja, Ardyn) refuse the mortality of a particular body, whether natural or designed. The *civilizational* Unsent (Yu Yevon, Emet-Selch, Sphene, Ultima) refuse the passing of a world—a city, a people, a race—and are, of all the series' villains, the most sympathetic, because their refusal is a form of love. The *theological* Unsent (the Occuria, the fal'Cie, Bhunivelze) refuse either the absence of god or the autonomy of history. The fifth modality is dialectical: the *nihilistic inversion* (Exdeath, Kefka, Necron, Meteion), in which the

refusal of passage, frustrated, converts itself into the will to annihilation. Its implicit syllogism runs: *if nothing may remain, then let nothing be*. Kefka and Sephiroth are therefore twins, not opposites. Both find passage unbearable; the one would keep everything by becoming god, the other would destroy everything because nothing can be kept. Freud would recognize in the second a figure of the death drive; this thesis reads it rather as the despair of the lithic, the crystal's rage at the river.

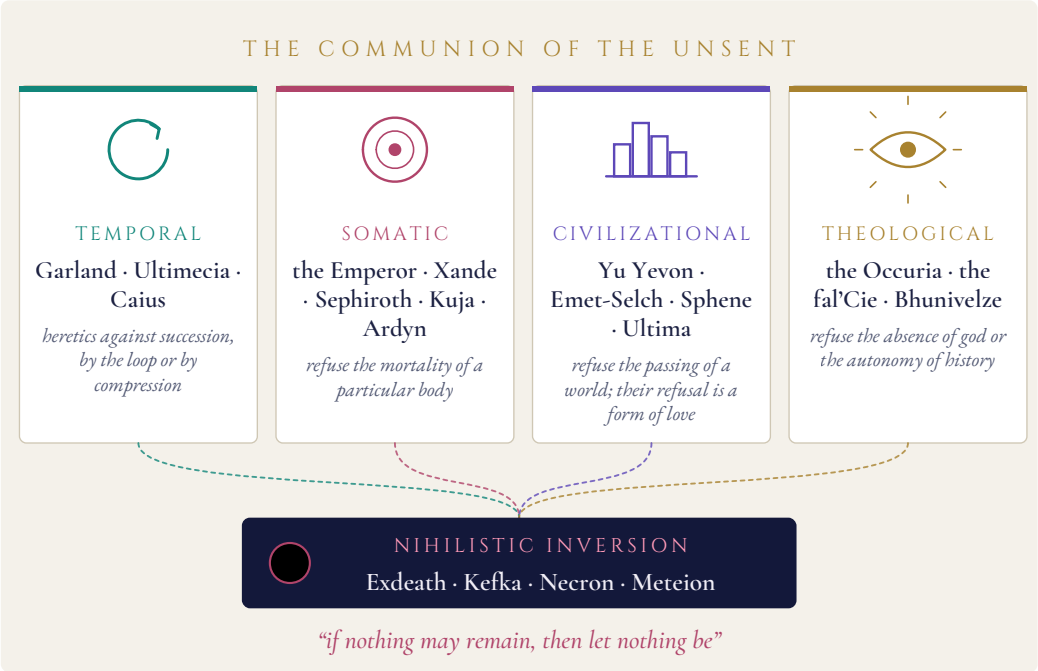


FIGURE 2 *A typology of refused passage: four modalities of the Communion, and the fifth, dialectical modality into which a frustrated refusal converts itself (§2.3).*

2.4 ◆ Necrostasis: The Dead Who Govern

Necrostasis designates a regime in which the refusal of passage is institutionalized, so that the dead—or the past, the canonical, the already-written—govern the living. Spira is its paradigm. The highest religious office is held by a corpse; the Teachings, which forbid the machina that might allow Spira to develop, are the law of the dead; Sin returns cyclically as punishment and is periodically quieted by the sacrifice of a summoner and a guardian, after which there follows the Calm. Marx's sentence in *The Eighteenth Brumaire* (1852)—"the tradition of all dead generations weighs like a nightmare on the brains of the living"—is, in Spira, not a metaphor but a constitution.

Three classical analyses converge here. Kant opened *Toward Perpetual Peace* (1795) by recalling a Dutch innkeeper's sign that bore the words "perpetual peace" above a painted graveyard; the Calm is that sign made into a polity, a peace of the cemetery purchased with ritual death.

Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor (1880) defends the deception of the faithful as mercy, offering them miracle, mystery and authority in place of an unbearable freedom; Mika, who knows the Teachings to be empty, and Yunalesca, who offers the Final Summoning as "hope," are his Spiran successors. Eliade's *Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) describes archaic societies that abolish history through cyclical regeneration, sheltering themselves from the "terror of history." *FF X* inverts Eliade's valuation exactly: the cycle is the terror, and history—irreversible, unrepeatable, open—is the liberation.

THE ROLL OF THE UNSENT

ENTRY	FIGURE	MODE OF REFUSED PASSAGE	INSTRUMENT
FF I	Garland / Chaos	Temporal	The two-thousand-year loop
FF II	The Emperor	Somatic	Return from Hell
FF III	Xande	Somatic, temporal	Darkness to arrest time
FF IV	Zemus / Zeromus	Affective	Hatred surviving its bearer
FF V	Exdeath	Nihilistic inversion	The Void (無)
FF VI	Kefka	Nihilistic inversion	Godhood; the Light of Judgment
FF VII	Sephiroth	Somatic, theological	Meteor; the Planet's wound; Reunion
FF VIII	Ultimecia	Temporal	Time compression
FF IX	Kuja; Necron	Somatic; nihilistic	The destruction of Terra; Eternal Darkness
FF X	Yu Yevon; Yunalesca; Seymour; Mika	Civilizational, institutional	Sin; the Final Summoning; the Teachings
FF XII	The Occuria	Theological (providence)	Nethicite
FF XIII	The fal'Cie	Theological (the Maker's return)	Focus; engineered mass death
XIII-2	Caius Ballad	Temporal, affective	Killing the goddess of death
Lightning Returns	Bhunivelze	Theological	A world remade
FF XIV	Emet-Selch; Meteion; Sphene	Civilizational; nihilistic	Rejoinings; the Endsinger; Living Memory
FF XV	Ardyn	Somatic	Immortality through the Starscourge
FF XVI	Ultima	Civilizational, theological	The vessel "Mythos"; the Mothercrystals

● *temporal* ● *somatic* ● *affective* ● *nihilistic* ● *theological* ● *civilizational* ● *institutional*

TABLE 2. *The Communion of the Unsent.*

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) supplies a modern comparandum for religion as deliberate political technology. Its Bene Gesserit sisterhood seeds prophecies across inhabited worlds through a Missionaria Protectiva so that its agents may later exploit them, and the desert's messianic faith is in part such a planted crop. Yevon is darker: its Teachings were not seeded by a cynical order but are maintained by a priesthood of the dead that knows them to be empty. Herbert's planetologist Liet-Kynes, who plans to transform Arrakis over centuries, is Bugenhagen's nearest literary kin, and the spice, harvested from the desert's own life cycle, is the closest Western analogue to mako.

The juridical form of necrostasis is the exception. Carl Schmitt defined the sovereign as "he who decides on the exception" (*Political Theology*, 1922); the Final Summoning is a sovereign exception in which the summoner is withdrawn from ordinary life into a consecrated condition whose terminus is death. The summoner thereby resembles Agamben's *homo sacer* (1995): life included in the order only through its exposure to death. The ontological form of necrostasis is the specter. Derrida's hauntology (1993) names a presence neither present nor absent, a past that will not pass; Spira is governed by such specters. Its psychic form is melancholia. Freud distinguished mourning, in which the libido is gradually withdrawn from the lost object, from melancholia, in which the lost object is incorporated and preserved within the ego (1917); he later identified a compulsion to repeat that overrides the pleasure principle (1920). Sin is a *Wiederholungszwang* on the scale of a civilization, the trauma of the ancient war between Zanarkand and Bevelle repeated without end. The Unsent are melancholia institutionalized; the Sending is mourning completed.

2.5 ◆ The Literature of Refused Death

The Communion of the Unsent belongs to a broad speculative tradition whose consensus is that immortality is not life prolonged but life cancelled. Gilgamesh loses the plant of rejuvenation to a serpent and returns to Uruk to admire its walls; in the Old Babylonian version, the alewife Siduri counsels him to delight in food, clean garments and the child who holds his hand. Swift's Struldbruggs (1726) are deathless and decrepit. Tolkien made death the Gift of Ilúvatar to Men, release from the circles of the world (*The Silmarillion*, 1977); debated whether it was gift or punishment in the "Athrabeth Finrod ah Andreth" (published 1993); condemned in his letters the Elves' wish to halt change and history as a kind of embalming; and narrated in the *Akallabêth* the fall of Númenor, whose envy of immortality ends in an art of preserving the dead flesh of Men and a land filled with silent tombs. Le Guin's *The Farthest Shore* (1972) shows a sorcerer's promise of eternal life draining the world of magic and meaning, and *The Other Wind* (2001) dismantles the wall that ancient mages raised to exempt the dead from rebirth, returning them to the cycle. Borges's "The Immortal" (1947) finds in the City of the Immortals a place where, since every act will be repeated infinitely, no act matters. Beauvoir's *All Men Are Mortal* (1946) follows Fosca through centuries of hollowing indifference. Čapek's *Makropulos Affair* (1922) prompted Bernard Williams's argument for the tedium of immortality (1973). Murakami Haruki's *Hard-Boiled Wonderland and the End of the World* (1985) imagines a walled Town whose inhabitants

surrender their minds in exchange for timeless peace. *Final Fantasy*'s distinctive contribution to this tradition is twofold: it converts the critique of immortality into a political economy (Chapter Three) and into a ludic form (Chapter Nine).

2.6 ◆ The Negative Image of the Sacred

The Communion of the Unsent is the series' negative theology. It shows what the sacred is not: not permanence, not retention, not return. Against it the series sets a positive figure—the one who sends—whose features Chapters Six through Eight draw. The present conclusion is structural. A world, in *Final Fantasy*, is endangered not by the fact that things end but by the refusal to let them; evil is the crystal's claim upon the river.

PART TWO

Economies and Polities

CHAPTER THREE
Necro-extractivism

CHAPTER FOUR
Empire, Sovereignty and the Mortal God

CHAPTER THREE

Necro-extractivism

Energy, Ecology and the Harvest of Souls

Necrostasis has a material base. In world after world of the series, the energy, labor and military power of the dominant order are drawn from the dead, or from life's capacity to pass on. This chapter names that political economy *necro-extractivism*, reconstructs it across the corpus, situates it in the Japanese experience of industrial catastrophe, and examines the series' ethics of resistance to it.

3.1 ◆ Mako: The Refinement of the Dead

FF VII opens inside the logic of extraction. Eight reactors ring Midgar, pumping the Lifestream out of the earth to be refined as mako and sold as electricity; the city's upper plate shelters the prosperous and its undercity the poor, in a vertical class geography descended from Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927). Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) supplies the obvious frame: modern technology is a mode of revealing, *Gestell* (enframing), that challenges nature to stand by as *Bestand*, standing reserve; its emblem is the hydroelectric plant set into the Rhine, which turns the river of Hölderlin's hymn into a supplier of water-pressure. Shinra's reactors are the Rhine plant at planetary scale. But *FF VII* radicalizes Heidegger in a direction he did not take. The standing reserve here is not merely nature; it is the dead, the souls of every creature that has lived upon the Planet. Shinra burns ancestors. Its ecological crime is therefore indistinguishable from desecration, and its reactors read as anti-shrines: where the *chinju no mori* (鎮守の森), the grove that surrounds a Shinto shrine, preserves a dwelling of kami and ancestral presence from use, the reactor converts that presence into fuel. The bodily index of the violation is mako poisoning, the condition that leaves Cloud catatonic; the Planet's index is its slow death, which Bugenhagen teaches the party to hear.

3.2 ◆ The Vampire and the Esper

Marx described capital as "dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour" (*Capital*, vol. 1, 1867, ch. 10). *FF VI* literalizes the figure. Gestahl's Empire extracts magic from captured Espers in its Magitek Research Facility, draining them until they wither, and channels the extracted power into Magitek armor and into human soldiers. Terra Branford, half-human and half-Esper, enters the story enslaved by a crown that suppresses her will: the extracted body as weapon. The vampire metaphor is then inverted with a precision Marx would have relished. Kefka, the first human infused with Magitek, is driven mad by it, and in the end the extractor becomes the god of what was extracted, enthroned atop a tower of debris as master of magic itself. Extraction does not merely deplete its object; it contaminates its subject.

3.3 ◆ The Labor of the Dead

FF IX converts the dead into a workforce. The Mist that issues from the Iifa Tree is composed of souls; in a hidden factory beneath the village of Dali it is condensed into black mages, puppet soldiers mass-produced for the wars of Queen Brahne and the arms trade of Kuja. Vivi, the prototype, is a soul conscripted before it understood that it lived. The comparative archive is extensive. Shelley's creature confronts its maker with the question of its making (*Frankenstein*, 1818); Dick's androids and Ridley Scott's replicants are engineered with fixed obsolescence (1968; 1982); Ishiguro's clones, raised to have their organs harvested, accept the shortness of their lives with a quietness that horrifies the reader (*Never Let Me Go*, 2005). *FF IX* belongs to this lineage but adds a cosmological premise: the material from which its slaves are made is the stream of the dead itself.

FF X names its bound laborers. The Fayth (祈り子, *inorigo*, literally "prayer-children") are persons whose souls were sealed into stone so that they might dream the aeons into being; for a thousand years they have also dreamed a city, Zanarkand, that perished long ago. Their labor is dreaming, and it is ceaseless. Their deepest wish, revealed late, is to be permitted to stop. The same structure recurs in *Dawntrail*, where the reconstituted dead of Living Memory are sustained by aether diverted from the natural circulation of souls; in *FF XV*, where the Ring of the Lucii draws the life of the one who wears it and the Crystal consumes the king; and in *FF XVI*, where the Mothercrystals drain the land's aether and the Bearers, persons born able to wield magic without crystals, are owned, branded and worked toward death (Chapter Four).

3.4 ◆ Theorizing Necro-extractivism

Necro-extractivism designates the conversion of the unreleased dead—or of life's capacity to pass on—into standing reserve. The concept extends three existing frames. Achille Mbembe's *necropolitics* (2003; 2019) names sovereignty as the power to decide who may live and who must die and to create "death-worlds"; the series adds that power does not merely kill but harvests the killed, so that the dead become the energy of the living order. Macarena Gómez-Barris's *extractive zone*

(2017) names the colonial-capitalist conversion of territories into resources; the series extends the zone downward, into the underworld. Jason W. Moore's account of capitalism's dependence on "cheap nature"—cheap food, energy, raw materials and labor (2015)—finds its mythic limit-case in mako, which is cheap death.

FIGURE 3 *Necro-extractivism: the conversion of the unreleased dead into standing reserve, and the three frames the concept extends (§3.4).*

The series' planetary imagination also anticipates recent ecological theory. The Lifestream and the Blight are what Timothy Morton calls *hyperobjects* (2013): entities so massively distributed in time and space that they cannot be perceived whole, only through local effects—a dying patch of soil, a poisoned body. The game, a medium able to render a planet as a navigable totality, is unusually suited to them. *FF VII*'s Weapons, colossal creatures the Planet releases to destroy what threatens it, give Lovelock's Gaia an immune system and anticipate the rhetoric of his late *The Revenge of Gaia* (2006). The game's final image, Midgar overgrown five hundred years after the story, the fate of humanity left open, belongs to what Anna Lowenhaupt Tsing calls life in capitalist ruins (2015) and to Morton's *dark ecology* (2016), the awareness that the one who diagnoses the catastrophe is implicated in it. Donna Haraway's call to "make kin" across species (2016) is anticipated by the series' interspecies parties, from Red XIII to the moogles.

Hans Jonas's *The Imperative of Responsibility* (1979) supplies the ethical counterweight. Its maxim enjoins action compatible with "the permanence of genuine human life on earth." The word must be read fluvially: Jonas asks not that anything be kept unchanged but that the stream of generations not be cut off. The permanence he defends is the continuance of passage, which is

exactly what necro-extractivism consumes; the Blight and the dying Planet are failures of Jonas's imperative before they are failures of anything else.

3.5 ◆ The Japanese Context

These preoccupations are not generic. Postwar Japan experienced industrial catastrophe with exceptional intimacy, and its agents were named in court. The "four great pollution diseases" (*yondai kōgai-byō*) were Minamata disease, officially identified in 1956 and caused by methylmercury in the wastewater that the Chisso Corporation's chemical plant discharged into Minamata Bay; its recurrence along the Agano River in Niigata, traced to Shōwa Denkō's plant upstream; *itai-itai* disease, caused by cadmium from the Mitsui Mining and Smelting Company's Kamioka mine; and Yokkaichi asthma, caused by sulfur oxides from the Yokkaichi petrochemical complex. The victims won all four suits between 1971 and 1973. Ishimure Michiko's *Kugai jōdo* (*Paradise in the Sea of Sorrow*, 1969) rendered Minamata in a register that fused testimony with Buddhist and animist cosmology. The record also answers Lynn White Jr.'s influential thesis that the ecological crisis has its roots in Christian anthropocentrism (1967): a culture of kami and sacred groves industrialized as destructively as any other. The series does not presume animism protective; it locates the crime in extraction, whatever the religion of the extractor.

Miyazaki Hayao's *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* (manga 1982–1994; film 1984) imagined a toxic forest that purifies the poisoned earth, and the manga concludes with Nausicaä's refusal of a sealed plan to replace the living, poison-adapted world with an engineered purity—a lithic salvation rejected in favor of impure, mortal life. *Princess Mononoke* (1997), released the same year as *FF VII*, sets an iron-making town against a forest god and carries the one-word tagline 生きろ, "Live." That year also saw *The End of Evangelion*. The constellation followed the collapse of the asset bubble (1991), the Great Hanshin earthquake (January 1995) and the attack of 20 March 1995, in which members of the apocalyptic cult Aum Shinrikyō, on the orders of its leader Asahara Shōkō, released sarin on Tokyo subway trains, killing more than a dozen people and injuring thousands—events that intensified what Napier calls anime's apocalyptic mode (2005). No claim of direct influence is made here; the claim is of a shared field of anxieties. Read in that field, and analogically, *FF VII*'s black-cloaked, numbered Sephiroth clones, drawn across the world toward a "Reunion" at the Northern Crater, and *Advent Children*'s Kadaj, who gathers sick orphans with the promise of a cure from "Mother," give the apocalyptic sect a place in the series' imagery; no documentary link to Aum is claimed.

Within the same field, *FF VII*'s mako has been read as a nuclear allegory (cf. Hutchinson 2019), and *FF X*'s Sin—the city-destroying punishment for a prohibited technology—as an image of the atomic bombings: the destruction of Hiroshima on 6 August and Nagasaki on 9 August 1945 by United States atomic bombs, which killed an estimated 140,000 and 74,000 people respectively by the end of that year. These readings stand in a postwar genealogy of the monster as nuclear punishment that begins with *Gojira* (Honda Ishirō, 1954), released months after a United States hydrogen-bomb test at Bikini Atoll irradiated the crew of the Japanese fishing boat

Daigo Fukuryū Maru. The relaunch of *Final Fantasy XIV* in 2013, as a world rebuilt after the Calamity of Dalamud's fall, came two years after the meltdowns at the Tokyo Electric Power Company's Fukushima Daiichi plant, which the Diet's independent investigation commission called "a profoundly manmade disaster" (2012). Shinra, it should be remembered, is an electric power company.

3.6 ◆ The Ethics of Sabotage

FF VII begins with a bombing. The insurgent cell AVALANCHE, led by Barret Wallace and joined for pay by Cloud, destroys Mako Reactor 1. The original game leaves the human cost largely offscreen; the *Remake* (2020) shows the aftermath in the streets, gives faces to the dead and injured, and gives guilt to the bombers. Measured by the usual definition of terrorism—violence against noncombatants to coerce political change—the attack qualifies, and Shinra's media call it terrorism. Shinra's reply is larger. President Shinra orders the plate over Sector 7 dropped onto the slum beneath it; the Turks carry out the order, Reno releasing the plate from its support pillar; the slum's inhabitants die in great numbers; and Shinra's broadcasts blame AVALANCHE. Two acts of political killing therefore frame the opening, unequal in scale and in intent—Shinra kills deliberately, AVALANCHE as a cost it chose to risk—but both kill noncombatants for political ends. The ethical question—whether violence against an infrastructure of death may be justified, and where its limit lies—has an exact literary precedent in Camus's *Les Justes* (1949), in which the revolutionary Kaliayev refuses to throw his bomb at the Grand Duke's carriage because children are inside. Michael Walzer's principle of noncombatant immunity (1977) states the limit in the language of just-war theory; Andreas Malm's *How to Blow Up a Pipeline* (2021), published between the *Remake* and *Rebirth*, revived the debate over sabotaging fossil infrastructure without harming people. The series' position is Camusian: the machine may be broken, the innocent may not be killed, and AVALANCHE, having killed them, must carry the weight. Barret's repentance is the moral form of that limit.

CHAPTER FOUR

Empire, Sovereignty and the Mortal God

The empire is the series' most persistent political form, and its anatomy is constant: it is technological, extractive and theological at once. This chapter argues that *Final Fantasy* stages a political theology made literal—gods, demons and engineered divinities stand behind its thrones—and that its protagonists, in rejecting the empire, also refuse the temptation to become it.

4.1 ◆ An Imperial Typology

The roster is long: Palamecia in *II*, Baron under Golbez's influence in *IV*, Gestahl's Empire in *VI*, the Shinra Company in *VII*, Galbadia in *VIII*, Alexandria under Queen Brahne in *IX*, Archadia in *XII*, the Sanctum of Cocoon in *XIII*, Niflheim in *XV*, Garlemald in *XIV*, Sanbreque and Waloed in *XVI*, and, in *Tactics*, the Church of Glabados, which governs through the crowns it legitimates. Three features recur. Every empire commands a superior technology: Magitek, mako, machina, airships, nethicite. Every empire extracts (Chapter Three). And every empire has a god or demon behind it—the Emperor's Hell, the Warring Triad, Jenova, the Lucavi, the renegade Occuria Venat, the fal'Cie, the Ascian Emet-Selch (who, as Solus zos Galvus, founded Garlemald), Ultima. Carl Schmitt argued that all significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts (1922). The series runs the thesis backward: its states are *re-sacralized*, their theological concepts restored to literal divinities. The documented debt of the early games to *Star Wars* (1977)—an Empire, a rebellion, a superweapon, soldiers named Biggs and Wedge—supplies the imperial template; the series fills it with theology.

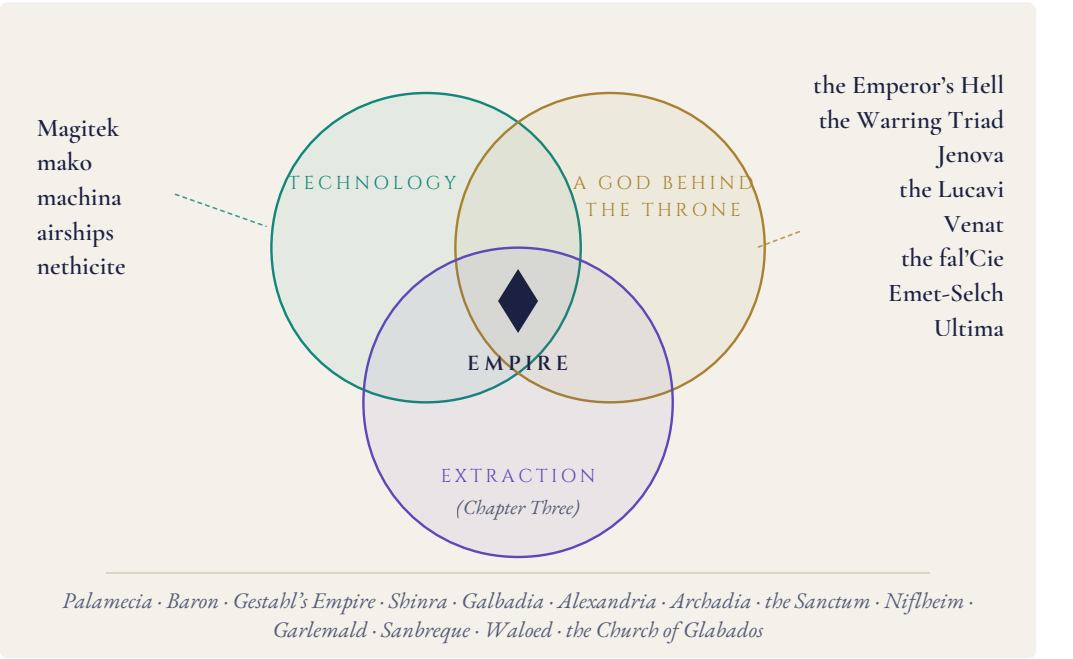


FIGURE 4 *The anatomy of empire: technological, extractive and theological at once (§4.1).*

4.2 ◆ Shinra: The Corporation as Sovereign

Shinra is the series' most modern empire because it is not a state. It controls energy, the army (SOLDIER), the police and an extralegal security force (the Turks), the press, urban planning, science and the space program; Midgar's mayor is a figurehead. Max Weber defined the state by its successful claim to the monopoly of legitimate violence (1919); Shinra holds that monopoly as a private company. Its most revealing act is the collapse of the Sector 7 plate, an atrocity ordered by President Shinra, executed by the Turks and attributed to the insurgents through a managed narrative. Arendt's essays on truth and lying in politics (1967; 1971) analyze the reality-replacing lie as a technique of modern power; Shinra's broadcast account of the disaster is its dramatic form. The game's synthesis of cyberpunk—the megacorporation of William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984), the Tyrell Corporation of *Blade Runner*—with high fantasy produces a figure that later theory would call neoliberal sovereignty, the absorption of the political by the economic (Brown 2015).

4.3 ◆ Archadia and the Mortal God

FF XII (2006), conceived by Matsuno Yasumi, is the series' most Thucydidean work. The small kingdoms of Dalmasca and Nabradia lie between the empires of Archadia and Rozarria, and their fate obeys the law the Athenians pronounced at Melos: the strong do what they can and the weak suffer what they must (Thucydides 5.89). The Nabradian capital, Nabudis, is annihilated

by the power of a shard of nethicite, a crystal that devours Mist; Princess Ashe, offered a similar power by the immortal Occuria with which to destroy Archadia, refuses to use it. The refusal reads as an allegory of the nuclear taboo, the normative inhibition against the use of weapons already possessed (Tannenwald 2007).

The game's philosophical structure is a double refusal. The Occuria are immortal gods who administer history by choosing whom to arm. The Archadian emperor Vayne Carudas Solidor, allied with the renegade Occuria Venat and the scientist Cid, seeks to wrest history from them and place it in human hands—a Promethean and humanist project. Vayne is Hobbes's sovereign, the "Mortal God" to whom, under the Immortal God, subjects owe their peace and defense (*Leviathan*, 1651, ch. 17). The protagonists fight both: the immortal gods who own history and the mortal god who would own it in their stead. Their freedom lies neither in providence nor in sovereign will but in what Arendt called plurality, the condition that men, not Man, inhabit the earth (1958). The Sun-Cryst is shattered, the Occuria's hold on history ends, and no Leviathan replaces them.

4.4 ◆ Ivalice of the Lion War: History Against the Grain

Final Fantasy Tactics (1997), also directed by Matsuno, sets a succession war loosely modeled on the Wars of the Roses within a church-state whose founding saint is a fraud. The Germonik Scriptures, recovered in the course of the plot, reveal that Saint Ajora was not a messiah but a figure entangled with the demonic Lucavi, and that the Church of Glabados has built its authority upon a falsified gospel. The structure recapitulates the history of historical-critical scholarship, from Reimarus's fragments (published 1774–1778) to Schweitzer's *Quest of the Historical Jesus* (1906), and the modern recovery of suppressed texts at Nag Hammadi (1945).

The frame is historiographical. A later scholar, Arazlam Durai, reconstructs from the Durai Papers the erased role of Ramza Beoulve, branded a heretic, while official history has credited the war's settlement to the commoner Delita Heiral, who rose to the throne by manipulation and murder. Walter Benjamin's "On the Concept of History" (1940) insists that every document of civilization is also a document of barbarism and that the historian must brush history against the grain; *Tactics* makes that brushing its narrative form. Delita is Machiavelli's new prince (*Il Principe*, 1532), combining the fox and the lion and governed by the gap between how one lives and how one ought to live; Ramza is a Kantian, acting on principle and paying for it with his name. Between them stands Wiegraf, leader of a commoners' revolt, whose descent into demonic possession enacts the fate Camus diagnosed in revolutions that abandon their limit. The ending —Delita crowned, wounded by and wounding the queen he married, asking the absent Ramza what he had gained—leaves sovereignty empty at its summit.

Hegel called history a slaughter-bench on which the happiness of peoples is sacrificed, and justified the sacrifice by the progress of Spirit (*Lectures on the Philosophy of History*, delivered 1822–1831). *Tactics* accepts the first clause and refuses the second. Its dead commoners purchase no progress. Delita's sister Tietra, held hostage by the Corpse Brigade at Fort Zeakden, is shot by the

noble squire Argath, for whom a commoner's life is not worth sparing; her death purchases only a throne for a man who will trust no one.

4.5 ◆ Social Death: Bearers, Branding and Marronage

FF XVI returns to slavery with unprecedented directness. In Valisthea those born able to wield magic without crystals, the Bearers, are owned, branded on the cheek, bought, sold and worked; magic so wielded slowly petrifies the user's flesh, so that the slave's labor turns the slave, literally, to stone. The lithic consumes the body. The brand recalls a historical practice: European slave traders and enslavers in the Atlantic world branded captive Africans as property. Orlando Patterson's definition of slavery as *social death*—natal alienation, general dishonor and permanent violent domination (1982)—fits the Bearers precisely, and Hegel's dialectic of lord and bondsman (1807) is visible in the dependence of Valisthea's prosperity upon the labor it despises. The closest analogue in recent speculative fiction is N. K. Jemisin's *Broken Earth* trilogy (2015–2017), whose orogenes, born with a power to move the earth, are bred, trained and leashed by an institution that calls its control protection; the deepest analogue is Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), a city whose happiness depends on one child's misery. Cid's Hideaway, the refuge in which escaped Bearers live as persons, is a maroon community of the kind that Africans who escaped enslavement formed across the Americas—Palmares in seventeenth-century Brazil, the Maroons of Jamaica—studied by Richard Price (1973). Frederick Douglass's *Narrative* (1845), in which a man the law classed as property writes himself into personhood, is the precedent for the Bearers' claim to be persons. Cid's aim—a world in which a person might live, and die, as a person rather than a tool—makes the right to a human death a political demand.

The resolution is structural rather than moral. By destroying the Mothercrystals, Clive removes the material basis of the economy that required Bearers; abolition arrives as disenchantment. The resolution invites critique: a technological abolition without political reconstruction risks a *deus ex machina*, and the game leaves the post-magical polity largely unwritten. Yet the logic is consistent with the thesis. The crystal produced the slave; the end of the crystal is the end of slavery's premise.

FF XIV supplies a different case. Its Japanese text has long called the tribes outside the dominant civilizations 蛮族 (*banzoku*, "barbarian tribes") and their gods 蛮神 (*banshin*, "barbarian gods"), the latter rendered in English as "primals." The nomenclature encodes an imperial perspective whose critique, after Said (1978), is evident; the game itself complicates it by revealing that the founding theology of "civilized" Ishgard is as fabricated as any tribal god (Chapter Seven), and the English client's later relabeling of the associated content as "allied societies" registers the pressure of that critique.

4.6 ◆ Biopolitics and Manufactured Life

Foucault located modern power in the shift from the sovereign right to take life or let live to the biopolitical power to make live and let die (1976; lectures of 1975–76), exercised through disciplinary institutions—the school, the barracks, the hospital—that produce docile bodies (1975). Agamben radicalized the analysis into a theory of bare life and the camp (1995). The series stages both. *FF VII*'s SOLDIER program produces supersoldiers by infusion with mako and the cells of Jenova; the mansion laboratory at Nibelheim, where Hojo holds Cloud and Zack for some four years as experimental specimens, injecting them with Jenova cells and suspending them in mako, is the camp in miniature—the camp that Agamben, generalizing from the concentration camps of the Nazi state, made the paradigm of modern biopolitics. *FF VIII*'s Gardens raise orphans into the mercenary force SeeD; *Type-0*'s Akademeia trains cadets for war; *FF XIII*'s l'Cie are branded by the gods; *FF IX*'s Genomes are grown as vessels for another world's souls; *FF X*'s summoners are raised for sacrifice.

Against manufacture the series sets what Arendt called *natality*: the capacity, given with every birth, to begin something new (1958). The manufactured beings of the series—Vivi, Zidane, Kuja, Cloud's constructed self, the l'Cie, the Bearers—reclaim natality by acting unpredictably against their design, as when Zidane, built by Garland to be an Angel of Death, refuses the function. Sartre's formula that existence precedes essence (1946) here meets its limit case: an essence imposed before existence, and then exceeded by it.

4.7 ◆ Measured Revolt

The political virtue the series most consistently honors is revolt within a limit. Camus's *The Rebel* (1951) defines rebellion as a simultaneous no and yes—refusal of an intolerable condition and affirmation of a value shared with others—and condenses it into a social cogito: "I rebel—therefore we exist." He distinguishes metaphysical rebellion, the creature's protest against the conditions of creation, from historical rebellion, and warns that both, once they abandon their limit, issue in murder. He traces metaphysical rebellion through the Romantic cult of the defiant outlaw, whose emblem is Milton's Satan, who would rather reign in Hell than serve in Heaven (*Paradise Lost*, 1667, I.263) and whom Blake read as the hero of Milton's secret sympathy (*The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*, c. 1790–1793). The series' charismatic villains descend from that line—Sephiroth's Miltonic refusal of his creaturely origin, Kuja's Byronic theater of defiance—and the series follows Camus in judging where it leads. Kefka's revolt against meaninglessness becomes murder in fact: as an imperial general he poisons the river that supplies Doma Castle, killing its people, among them the knight Cyan's wife and son; as a god he burns towns with the Light of Judgment. Sephiroth's revolt against his origin becomes a claim to godhood purchased with the burning of Nibelheim and the summoning of Meteor; Wiegraf's class revolt becomes demonic. The series' heroes are rebels who keep the limit: the Wild Rose of *II*, AVALANCHE

after its reckoning, the Hideaway of *XVI*. The party is Camus's "we" given a body, and its defining refusal is to become the empire it fights—to be, in Camus's phrase of 1946, neither victims nor executioners.

PART THREE

Persons

CHAPTER FIVE
Mnemopolitics

CHAPTER SIX
Being-toward-the-Credits

CHAPTER FIVE

Mnemopolitics

Memory, Identity and the Right to Be Forgotten

Memory in *Final Fantasy* is never neutral storage; it is a field of power. The series distinguishes three regimes—crystalline amnesia, crystalline hypermnesia and fluvial anamnesis—and grounds personal identity not in retained memory but in the promise.

5.1 ◆ Cloud Strife and the Problem of Personal Identity

Cloud presents himself as a former SOLDIER First Class. He was in fact an infantryman who never attained that rank. After the catastrophe at Nibelheim he was subjected, with the SOLDIER Zack Fair, to experiments that infused him with mako and Jenova cells; after Zack's death, Cloud's mind assembled a self from Zack's memories, his own longing and the mimetic capacities of the alien cells. In the Lifestream at Mideel, Tifa enters his consciousness and helps him recover what actually happened.

The case is a philosophical laboratory. Locke made personal identity consist in sameness of consciousness extended backward by memory (*Essay*, 2nd ed., 1694, II.xxvii); by that criterion Cloud would partly be Zack. Joseph Butler objected that memory presupposes identity rather than constituting it (1736); Thomas Reid's brave-officer paradox exposed the criterion's failure of transitivity (1785). Sydney Shoemaker answered Butler with the concept of *quasi-memory*, an apparent memory caused in the right way by an experience that need not have been the rememberer's own (1970); Cloud is a fictional instance of quasi-memory at full scale. Derek Parfit concluded that identity is not what matters; what matters is psychological connectedness and continuity, "Relation R" (1984); at certain moments Cloud is more R-related to Zack than to his own past. Hume's bundle theory (1739) and the Buddhist doctrine of no-self (*anattā*), illustrated in

the *Milindapañha* by the chariot that is nothing over and above its parts and by the flame passed from lamp to lamp, would dissolve the problem altogether.

FF VII accepts none of these resolutions. It locates Cloud's recovery in a childhood promise, made to Tifa beneath the village water tower, that he would come to save her if she were ever in trouble, and lets the reconstructed memory crystallize around that promise. Paul Ricoeur's distinction between *idem*-identity, sameness of character and memory, and *ipse*-identity, selfhood as constancy to one's word, exemplified by promise-keeping (*Oneself as Another*, 1990), describes the game exactly. Cloud's *idem* collapses; his *ipse* refounds him. He is who he promised to be. Arendt had identified the faculty of promising as the remedy for the unpredictability of action, and the faculty of forgiving as the remedy for its irreversibility (1958). *Advent Children* completes the pair: Cloud, consumed by guilt for the deaths of Zack and Aerith and surrounded by the Geostigma that the film makes the somatic form of grief, is healed by forgiveness and by rain.

Two further readings sharpen the case. Judith Butler's account of identity as citational performance (1990) is staged with comic exactness in the Wall Market sequence, whose cross-dressed infiltration of Don Corneo's mansion makes the performative character of all Cloud's personae visible; Erving Goffman's dramaturgy of the self (1956) is its sociological precedent. And René Girard's theory of mimetic desire (1961) explains the genesis of the false self: Cloud wished to be Sephiroth, then became Zack; Jenova, a being that assumes the forms its victims remember and desire, is mimetic desire given a biology.

5.2 ◆ Guardian Forces and the Price of Power

FF VIII makes memory the currency of power. Its soldiers junction Guardian Forces to their minds, and the junctioning slowly displaces memory. The revelation comes late: Squall, Quistis, Zell, Selphie and Seifer were raised together in an orphanage by Edea, the sorceress they have been fighting, and all but Irvine, who did not rely on Guardian Forces, have forgotten. Nietzsche had argued that action requires the capacity to feel "unhistorically," to forget (1874); the Gardens industrialize that capacity, producing soldiers able to fight their own foster mother because they no longer remember her. The game's temporal structure compounds the problem of origin. Squall, cast into the past, tells the young Edea of SeeD and the Gardens, and she goes on to found them; the institution has no beginning outside the loop. Heinlein's "By His Bootstraps" (1941) and "—All You Zombies—" (1959) are its precedents, and Derrida's "originary supplement" (1967), the origin always already constituted by what was supposed to follow it, its theory. Against the loop the game sets a promise: Rinoa's promise to meet Squall in the flower field, which returns him from compressed time (Chapter Eight).

The Laguna sequences add a collective dimension. Through Ellone's power to send a consciousness into another's past, Squall's party lives fragments of an elder generation's life before learning their significance. Maurice Halbwachs argued that individual memory is always framed by the memory of groups (1925; 1950); *FF VIII* literalizes the frame, transmitting a father's past to a son who does not yet know him.

5.3 ◆ Type-0: Crystalline Amnesia as State Technology

Type-0 (2011) imagines the political limit of forgetting. In Orience, each of four nations is patron to a crystal, and the crystals erase from the living the memory of the dead. Soldiers fall and are forgotten; no one mourns; war is therefore endless. Renan had argued that forgetting, and even historical error, is an essential factor in the creation of a nation: "L'oubli, et je dirai même l'erreur historique, sont un facteur essentiel de la création d'une nation" (1882). Orience literalizes the claim; each nation's crystal is its organ of forgetting. Freud's account of mourning (1917) explains the consequence. Mourning requires remembering the lost in order to release them; where memory is erased, mourning becomes impossible, and the unmourned return as repetition. The world of *Type-0* is caught in exactly such a repetition, an iterated cycle staged by its own hidden designer. Ricoeur warned against the abuses of "commanded forgetting," of which amnesty is the juridical model (2000); *Type-0* depicts commanded forgetting as a technology of total war. Its conclusion, in which the dying cadets of Class Zero find that they remember one another, restores grief—and with grief, history.

The allegory has a near referent, named here as analogy rather than influence. Postwar Japan's own politics of memory turned on commanded forgetting. From 1965 to 1997 the historian Ienaga Saburō sued the state over Ministry of Education textbook screening that had required him to delete or soften accounts of wartime atrocities, among them the lethal human experiments carried out on prisoners by the Imperial Japanese Army's Unit 731 in occupied Manchuria, and the mass killing and rape of Chinese prisoners and civilians by Japanese troops after the capture of Nanjing in December 1937. In 1997 the Supreme Court held several of the required changes unlawful, including the deletion of the passage on Unit 731. *Type-0*'s crystals stage as fantasy a question that Japanese courts and classrooms adjudicated in fact: whether a state may make its living forget the dead it made.

5.4 ◆ Spira's Dream: Tidus and the Butterfly

Tidus learns that he, his father and his city are the dream of the Fayth. The precedent is not primarily Descartes's dream argument (1641) but the parable at the close of the second chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, in which Zhuang Zhou dreams he is a butterfly and wakes not knowing whether he is a man who dreamed a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming a man—a passage whose point is not skepticism but the "transformation of things" (物化, *wuhua*). Tidus's dissolution at the end of *FF X* is such a transformation rather than an annihilation. Calderón's *La vida es sueño* (1635) supplies the Baroque counterpart; Baudrillard's simulacrum (1981), a copy without an original, describes Dream Zanarkand, a city that has outlived the city it copies; Murakami's Town at the End of the World (1985), a dreamed enclosure its protagonist chooses not to leave, supplies the modern Japanese one. Tidus chooses otherwise. The decisive datum is that the dreamers themselves ask to stop: the dream requests its own end, and the dreamed one consents.

Spira's recording technology is the sphere, which preserves image and voice; Jecht's spheres, left for his son, are the game's most moving documents. *FF X-2* (2003) turns sphere-hunting into a commercial occupation and stages, through the ghosts Shuyin and Lenne, a grief one thousand years old replaying itself through recorded memory—the Unsent as unprocessed trauma.

5.5 ◆ Amaurot and the Endless: Hypermnesia

Shadowbringers (2019) takes the player to the floor of an ocean where Emet-Selch has rebuilt Amaurot, the capital of his lost civilization, from memory, and peopled it with simulacra of its citizens. The precedent is Lem's *Solaris* (1961), whose ocean materializes from human memory the dead whom its visitors loved. Emet-Selch's final request, after his defeat—"Remember us. Remember that we once lived"—marks a turning point in the Communion of the Unsent. He asks for memory, not restoration. Where Sephiroth refuses to become a memory, Emet-Selch consents to become one. The opposition defines the poles of the series' mnemopolitics.

Pierre Nora distinguished living memory, carried by communities, from the *lieux de mémoire* —archives, monuments, commemorations—that societies build when that memory dies (1984–1992). Emet-Selch's Amaurot is a *lieu de mémoire* in the most literal sense, a site constructed because the community that remembered is gone; Spira's ruined Zanarkand, where pilgrims end their journey, is another. The series honors such sites only when they are acknowledged as sites of absence rather than presented as resurrections.

Dawntrail (2024) carries the problem into the digital. Living Memory preserves the dead of a technologically advanced civilization as the Endless, reconstituted from recorded memories and sustained by aether withheld from the natural circulation of souls; its keeper, Queen Sphene, maintains it out of love. The protagonists' decision to let the Endless end is the series' most explicit articulation of a right to be forgotten that belongs to the dead. Borges's Funes (1942), who forgets nothing and therefore cannot think, since thinking requires forgetting differences, is its literary premise. Bernard Stiegler's account of "tertiary retention," memory externalized in technical supports (1994), is its theoretical frame. Its cultural context is the contemporary imaginary of digital afterlives: Moravec's mind uploading (1988), Kurzweil's singularity (2005), Ted Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010), the half-life of the dead in Dick's *Ubik* (1969), and the *Black Mirror* episodes "Be Right Back" (2013) and "San Junipero" (2016). Its juridical analogue is the right to erasure codified in the European Union's General Data Protection Regulation (2016, art. 17) after the Court of Justice's *Google Spain* judgment (2014).

5.6 ◆ Three Regimes of Memory

The series distinguishes three regimes. *Crystalline amnesia* erases: the Guardian Forces, Orience's crystals. *Crystalline hypermnesia* retains without release: Living Memory, the reconstructed Amaurot, the sphere as fetish. Both are lithic, the one by deletion, the other by petrification. The third regime is *fluvial anamnesis*: memory that releases what it remembers. Its emblem is Yuna's

address at the close of *FF X*, delivered after the last Sending, in which she asks Spira never to forget those it has lost—remembrance offered as the completion of release, not its alternative. Whitehead's objective immortality (Chapter One) is its metaphysics. Plato's Myth of Er supplies its measure: before rebirth the souls drink from the River of Unmindfulness, and those not saved by wisdom drink more than the measure (*Republic* 621a). The ideal is neither total retention nor total oblivion but the measure—to drink exactly as much of Lethe as passage requires.

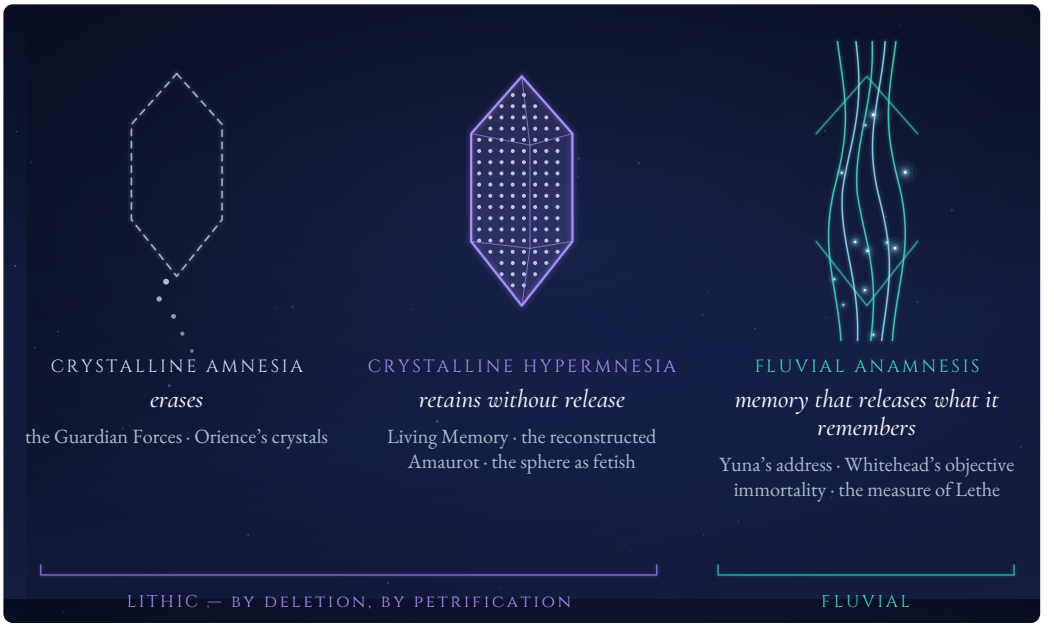


FIGURE 5 *Three regimes of memory. Both lithic regimes petrify, by deletion or by retention; the third remembers in order to release (§5.6).*

FF IX's Memoria, a place assembled from the memories of its travelers and of the planet, gives the third regime a space. Bergson argued that the past survives whole as a "pure memory" upon which the present draws selectively for action (*Matière et mémoire*, 1896). Memoria is that reservoir made walkable, and it leads, at its end, to the primordial Crystal: the series' one image of the lithic as source rather than prison.

CHAPTER SIX

Being-toward-the-Credits

Death, Finitude and the Gift of Mortality

The series' meditation on death corrects Heidegger with Watsuji, grounds mortality in the idea of a gift, and arrives—through the black mages, Aerith, Tidus, Noctis and the nihilists—at a temporality that Dōgen named eight centuries ago.

6.1 ◆ Heidegger and Watsuji

In *Being and Time* (1927, §§46–53) Heidegger argued that Dasein can be grasped as a whole only in relation to its death, which is its ownmost, non-relational, certain yet indefinite possibility, not to be outstripped; the anonymous "one" (*das Man*) evades it by saying that "one dies"; authentic existence anticipates it in resoluteness. Watsuji Tetsurō, who read *Being and Time* in Berlin in 1927, answered in *Fūdo* (1935) and *Rinrigaku* (1937–1949) that Heidegger had privileged time over space and the individual over relation. The Japanese word for the human being, *ningen* (人間), designates literally the "between" of persons; human existence is *aidagara*, betweenness. Death, too, occurs in betweenness: one dies among others and continues in them.

Two older positions frame the debate. Epicurus argued that death is nothing to us, since where death is, we are not (*Letter to Menoeceus*), and Lucretius added that the nonexistence after death should trouble us no more than the nonexistence before birth (*De rerum natura* III). Plato's Socrates, by contrast, called philosophy the practice of dying (*Phaedo* 64a), and Montaigne gave the theme an essay (*Essais* I.20, 1580). The series accepts neither the Epicurean dissolution of death's harm nor the philosopher's solitary rehearsal of it. Death matters in *Final Fantasy* because it is undergone among others and ends a life that others share.

The series' deaths are scenes of betweenness. Aerith dies before the party and is laid in the water by Cloud. Galuf, in *FF V*, falls defending his companions and passes his abilities to his granddaughter Krile. Tellah, in *FF IV*, spends his life on a single spell; the twins Palom and Porom turn themselves to stone to save their companions. Zack dies with Cloud beside him, entrusting him with the life he will not live. Being-toward-death becomes being-toward-death-together.

6.2 ◆ Xande and the Gift of Mortality

FF III contains the series' charter on death. The archmage Noah bequeathed gifts to his three disciples: to Doga, magical power; to Unei, the world of dreams; to Xande, a mortal life. Xande, resenting the gift, allied himself with darkness to stop the flow of time. The structure is Tolkien's. In *The Silmarillion* death is the Gift of Ilúvatar to Men, which in time even the immortal Powers shall envy; its refusal by the Númenóreans is the root of their fall. The *Epic of Gilgamesh*, Swift's Struldbruggs, Beauvoir's Fosca and Williams's tedium argument (Chapter Two) reach the same conclusion by different routes. Martha Nussbaum's argument that the distinctively human excellences—courage, generosity and love among them—presuppose finitude (1989; 1994) gives it ethical form: an immortal being could not have our virtues. *FF III* states the thesis in mythic shorthand. Mortality is a gift, and its refusal is the origin of cosmic evil.

6.3 ◆ Vivi Ornitier and the Invention of Burial

FF IX is the series' most sustained meditation on death, and its theory is anthropological. In the hidden Black Mage Village, black mages who have escaped their makers discover that their kind "stops" after about a year. They do not understand death, but they bury the stopped in a cemetery they have made. Vico held that all nations are founded upon three institutions—religion, solemn marriage and burial—and derived *humanitas* from *humando*, "burying" (*Scienza nuova*, 1744). The black mages become human by inventing burial. Vivi's questions throughout the game—how one proves that one exists, what it means to have been made—are answered not by argument but by relation: he exists because he matters to others. His valedictory monologue over the ending gathers his memories and commits them to those who remain, among them the small black mages he calls his children.

Kuja is Vivi's inverse. Made by Garland as an instrument and given a limited span, he strikes down his creator and learns of his own mortality from the dying man; in rage he then destroys the world of Terra. Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* (1973) describes the *causa sui* project by which human beings attempt to become their own origin and so escape the terror of death; Kuja's theatrical narcissism is such a project, costumed as Byron's defiant, self-dramatizing hero (*Manfred*, 1817). Kierkegaard distinguished the despair of weakness from the despair of defiance, in which the self in despair wills to be itself (*The Sickness unto Death*, 1849); Kuja is defiance incarnate. Roy Batty, the replicant of *Blade Runner* who kills his maker over the lifespan he was

given, is his cinematic double, and Kuja, too, kills his maker. Kuja's final act, however, converts defiance into care: dying, he spends the last of his power to carry the party out of the collapsing depths of the Iifa Tree. The series offers even its Unsent the possibility of being sent.

6.4 ◆ Aerith and the Problem of the Phoenix Down

When Sephiroth kills Aerith in the Forgotten Capital, the player holds in inventory an item that revives fallen allies, and it is useless. The contradiction is often cited as the paradigm of what Clint Hocking named ludonarrative dissonance (2007). It is better read as the argument itself. Jesper Juul has shown that games are organized around failure that can be undone (2013). The KO is a ludic death: reversible, administrable, lithic. Aerith's death is a narrative death: irreversible, fluvial. The game teaches the difference by refusing to let the instrument of reversal touch her. The moment at which the fluvial breaks through the lithic is the series' most famous scene because it is the moment at which the medium confronts its own power over death and lays it down.

FIGURE 6 *Two deaths. The game teaches the difference by refusing to let the instrument of reversal touch Aerith (§6.4).*

The *Remake* project returns to that moment as its central problem. *Remake* (2020) introduces the Whispers, arbiters who enforce the events of the 1997 original, and lets the party defeat them; *Rebirth* (2024) stages Aerith's death while doubling it, so that Cloud perceives her alive in a world that has begun to split. The trilogy thus becomes the series' supreme test of its own ethics: whether the franchise will un-send its most famous dead. The concluding installment lies outside this corpus, and the question remains open (Chapter Nine).

6.5 ◆ Sacrificial Finitude: Tidus, Noctis, Ardyn

René Girard argued that archaic societies discharge their internal violence upon a scapegoat whose sacrifice restores order, that myth conceals the victim's innocence, and that the Gospels reveal it (1972; 1978; 1982). Spira's Final Summoning is a scapegoat ritual: a summoner and a beloved guardian are sacrificed for the Calm. Yuna's refusal of it is a Girardian revelation—the

mechanism exposed, the victim's innocence declared. Tidus's disappearance after Yu Yevon's defeat is not a renewal of sacrifice but its end: the dream ceases because the system that required dreaming has been destroyed. It is the sacrifice of the sacrificial system.

FF XV is more ambivalent. Noctis, the True King, must give his life to purge the world of the Starscourge, and he accepts. His models are Kierkegaard's knight of faith (*Fear and Trembling*, 1843), who, like Abraham, consents to what ethics cannot justify, and Camus's Sisyphus, whom one must imagine happy (1942). His antagonist Ardyn is the series' purest scapegoat: a healer who drew the plague into his own body, was rejected by the gods and erased from history, and was rendered immortal by what he absorbed. Derrida showed that Plato's *pharmakon* means both remedy and poison and that the *pharmakos* is the expelled scapegoat (1968); Ardyn is both at once. The game exposes the cruelty of the sacrificial order it enacts without escaping it. The reconsideration that followed—*Episode Ardyn* (2019) and the novel *The Dawn of the Future* (2019), which develops the abandoned plans for further episodes and imagines king and scapegoat turning together against the god who designed their fates—reads as the franchise's own unease with the sacrificial resolution.

6.6 ◆ Nihilism and the Litanic Response

The series' nihilists share an argument: life ends; therefore nothing matters; therefore annihilation is mercy. Kefka mocks hope as a meaningless invention before the final battle of *FF VI*; Neo Exdeath would return all things to the Void; Necron, at the end of *FF IX*, offers nothingness as the cure for the fear of death; Meteion, in *Endwalker*, returns from the edge of the universe, where the civilizations she found had perished in despair, bearing a song that would end all things. Their philosophical relatives are Schopenhauer, for whom life swings like a pendulum between pain and boredom (1818/1844, §57); Peter Wessel Zapffe, for whom consciousness is an evolutionary overreach (1933); David Benatar, for whom coming into existence is always a harm (2006); and Thomas Ligotti (2010). Meteion's survey of dead worlds, at a place the game calls Ultima Thule after the classical name for the farthest north, has its precedent in Olaf Stapledon's cosmic survey of civilizations, *Star Maker* (1937).

FF VI first stages the response at the scale of a single life. After the world's ruin, Celes wakes on a desert island where Cid, her guardian, has nursed her through a year of unconsciousness. The player must keep him alive in turn by catching and feeding him fish. If the player fails, Cid dies, and Celes, believing herself the last survivor, climbs the island's cliff and throws herself from it in an attempt to end her life. She survives. On the shore she finds a wounded seabird whose wing is bound with Locke's bandana, the first sign that anyone else lives, and she sets out to find her companions. Three features of the episode matter to the argument. Despair is answered not by a reason but by a particular, a strip of cloth that proves a bond. The answer arrives as a sign of another's survival, so it is relational rather than solitary. And the branch is the player's doing: whether Cid lives depends on the player's care, so the game makes the player answerable for a death and for the despair that follows it.

The series answers nihilism not with a counter-argument but with a litany. Before Kefka, each member of the party names what makes life worth living—love, friendship, family, a child's future—each a particular; in *Endwalker*, the voices of the living and the dead gather against the Endsinger. This thesis calls the form the *litanic response*: the answer to universal negation is the enumeration of particular affirmations. Its philosophical justification is threefold. Wittgenstein wrote that the solution of the problem of life is seen in the vanishing of the problem (*Tractatus* 6.521, 1921): the litany does not solve the question but dissolves it in living. William James argued that the belief that life is worth living helps create the fact (1895). Most deeply, Nishitani Keiji held that nihility (*kyomu*) must be passed through rather than refuted, to arrive at the standpoint of emptiness (*śūnyatā*), where each thing appears in its own "home-ground" precisely as impermanent and interdependent (1961). The litany is the speech of that standpoint. Each item affirmed is affirmed as passing and as related; none is a crystal.

6.7 ◆ Dōgen: Firewood and Ash

The series' final temporal insight was formulated in Kamakura Japan. In "Genjōkōan" (1233), Dōgen observes that firewood becomes ash and does not return to being firewood; yet one should not view the ash as after and the firewood as before. Firewood abides in its own dharma-position (法位, *hōi*), which has a before and an after but is cut off from both. So too life does not become death: life is a position in time, and death is a position in time, like winter and spring. In "Uji" (1240) he names the identity of being and time: each moment is the whole of time. This temporality is neither the lithic eternity in which nothing passes nor the cyclical recurrence in which everything returns. It is *passage as completion*, each moment complete and each moment released.

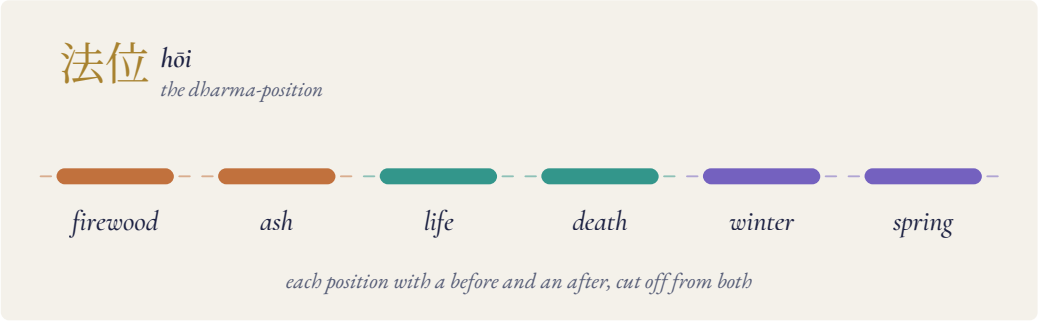
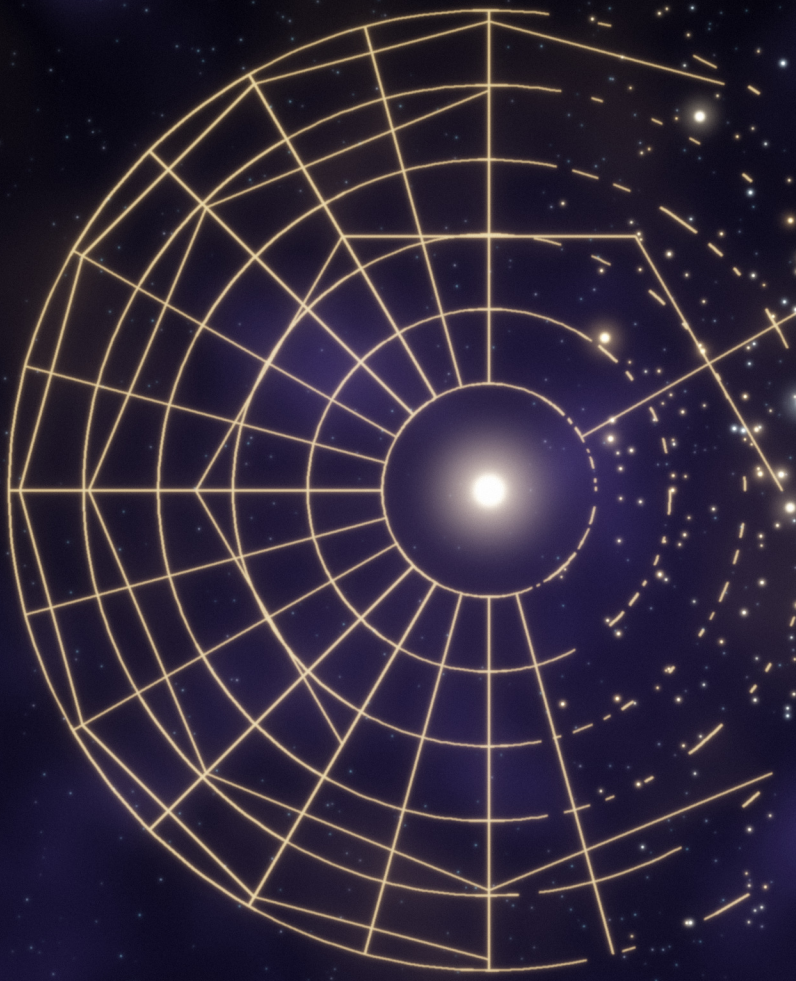


FIGURE 7 *Dōgen's dharma-positions: firewood and ash, life and death, winter and spring, each complete in its own position in time (§6.7).*

The credits of a *Final Fantasy* game occupy this position. They are not the failure of a world but its dharma-position. The player's relation to them may be called *being-toward-the-credits*: an anticipatory relation to the end of a world that, in principle, can be replayed indefinitely. Hans Vaihinger's *Philosophy of "As If"* (1911) held that consciously adopted fictions can be practically

indispensable. The series asks its player to treat the end *as if* it were final; its wager is that as-if finitude can school the real kind.



PART FOUR

Gods and Forms

CHAPTER SEVEN
From Chaoskampf to Kosmoskampf

CHAPTER EIGHT
The Monomyth without Return

CHAPTER NINE
Autotheomachy

CHAPTER SEVEN

From Chaoskampf to Kosmoskampf

Theomachy and the Death of the Gods

The series begins with the oldest plot in mythology, the god's combat against chaos, and ends by inverting it. This chapter traces the inversion, names its terminus *Kosmoskampf*, reads its theological grammar as an inverted Gnosticism, and shows that its most mature form is not deicide but kenosis.

7.1 ◆ The Archaic Theomachy

In the *Enūma Eliš*, Marduk slays the primordial sea-mother Tiamat, splits her body like a fish for drying and makes heaven and earth from the halves. Hermann Gunkel named the pattern *Chaoskampf* (1895) and traced its echoes in the Hebrew Bible, where Yahweh crushes Leviathan and Rahab (Psalm 74:13–14; Isaiah 27:1; Job 41). Hesiod's *Theogony* narrates the Titanomachy and Zeus's defeat of Typhon; the *Kojiki* (712) has Susanoo slay the eight-headed serpent Yamata no Orochi and draw the sword Kusanagi from its tail; the Norse *Völuspá* ends the age of the gods at Ragnarök. One variant is especially significant. In *Ṛgveda* 1.32, Indra slays Vṛtra, whose name derives from the root *vṛ*, "to cover, to enclose," the serpent who had dammed the waters; with the obstructor dead, the rivers run to the sea. The oldest Indo-European theomachy is already a liberation of the stream from its obstruction—an archetype of the fluvial against the lithic.

Final Fantasy's bestiary is a museum of these combats. Tiamat is a Fiend of *FF I*, by way of the five-headed dragon queen of *Dungeons & Dragons* (Gygax 1977). Bahamut, the cosmic fish of Arabic cosmology catalogued by Borges in his *Book of Imaginary Beings* (1957), became the king of dragons in the same game and then the series' supreme summon. Leviathan, Odin, Ragnarok, Kusanagi, Masamune and Excalibur recur throughout.

7.2 ◆ Early Chaoskampf (FF I–V)

The first five games largely preserve the archaic pattern. The threat is disorder, nothingness or imbalance; the good is the restoration of cosmic order through the crystals. Chaos and the Fiends in *I*, the Emperor in *II*, the Cloud of Darkness in *III*, Zeromus in *IV* and Exdeath's Void in *V* are enemies of the cosmos. Even here, however, the seed of inversion is present in *FF I*, whose enemy is not chaos alone but a closed loop of time.

7.3 ◆ The Inversion: Gods of Order

From *FF VI* onward the divine adversaries are agents of order, design and providence. Kefka seizes godhood by displacing the statues of the Warring Triad, whose balance was the source of magic. Sephiroth aspires to become a god by absorbing the Lifestream. Ultimecia would rule time itself. Yevon is an order of law. The Occuria administer history. The fal'Cie manage Cocoon and assign Focus. The primals of *FF XIV*, and above them Zodiark and Hydaelyn, are gods summoned to impose or to guard an order. Bahamut, in *FF XV*, designs the sacrificial destiny of kings. Ultima, in *FF XVI*, is a designer whose creatures are instruments.

This thesis calls the resulting structure *Kosmoskampf*: theomachy directed against a cosmos whose order is purchased by the arrest of time. Where the *Chaoskampf* founds order by killing chaos, the *Kosmoskampf* liberates time by killing order. Its genealogy is the history of metaphysical protest: Prometheus stealing fire (Hesiod; Aeschylus) and unbound (Percy Shelley, 1820); Job demanding an answer; Ivan Karamazov returning his ticket to a harmony purchased with a child's tears (1880)—the exact moral structure of *FF X*'s refusal of a Calm purchased with summoners' deaths; Bakunin's inversion of Voltaire, that if God really existed it would be necessary to abolish him (1882); Nietzsche's announcement that God is dead and that we have killed him (*The Gay Science* §125, 1882); Camus's metaphysical rebellion (1951). *Dragon Quest* (1986), the series' great domestic counterpart, largely preserves the *Chaoskampf*, setting its heroes against demon lords; the divergence of the two franchises is the divergence of the two theomachies.

7.4 ◆ Gnostic Grammar, Inverted

Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) reconstructed the ancient Gnostic vision: the cosmos is a prison fashioned by an ignorant creator, the Demiurge—Yaldabaoth, who in the *Apocryphon of John* boasts that there is no god beside him—and governed by archons who enforce fate (*heimarmenē*); beyond it is an alien, absent God; salvation is *gnosis*, the awakening of the divine spark to its exile. *FF XIII* is the series' most complete Gnostic text. Cocoon is a sphere-world, a literal cosmic shell, governed by fal'Cie who brand human beings as l'Cie and impose upon them a Focus: archons enforcing *heimarmenē*. The Maker has departed. The Primarch, Galenth Dysley, is the fal'Cie Barthandelus in human form, an archon masked as a ruler. *Lightning Returns* completes the schema with Bhunivelze, a creator who would remake the world in his own image and pos-

sess Lightning as his instrument: Yaldabaoth. *FF X* contributes the archontic law of Yevon and the gnosis disclosed at Zanarkand, and its English localization imported the Valentinian term for divine emanations, "aeons," for beings the Japanese text calls simply summoned beasts.

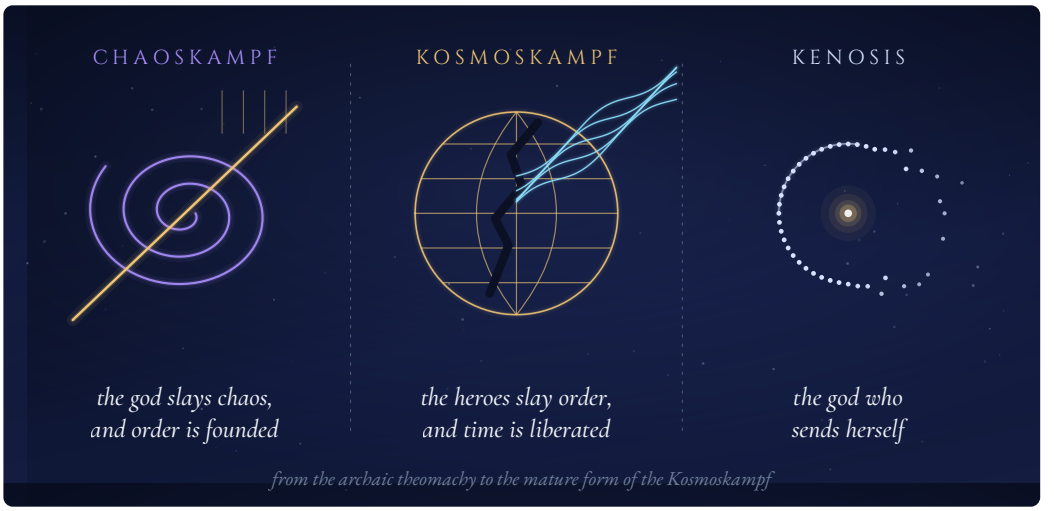


FIGURE 8 *From the archaic theomachy to the mature form of the Kosmoskampf, in which deicide gives way to kenosis (§§7.1–7.6).*

Cocoon is also a comfort-sphere. Its citizens live provisioned by fal'Cie that supply food, light, water and climate, and the Sanctum stages a Purge of everyone suspected of contact with the world outside. Sloterdijk's account of the climate-controlled "world interior" of capital (2005) and Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932), in which domination works through comfort, describe the archons' second instrument: not only fate imposed but need satisfied. The l'Cie are those expelled from the interior, and their gnosis begins with the loss of comfort.

Yet the series inverts Gnostic soteriology. Gnosis traditionally leads to acosmism, flight from the world toward the alien God. In *Final Fantasy* gnosis leads back to the world. Having learned that their gods are archons, the protagonists do not seek a higher heaven; they choose the earth, its mortality and its history. They are Gnostics of the earth, obedient to Zarathustra's injunction, *Bleibt der Erde treu*, "remain faithful to the earth" (1883, Prologue §3). The contemporary comparanda share the Gnostic premise but divide on its conclusion: Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981), the Wachowskis' *The Matrix* (1999), Square's own *Xenogears* (1998) and Anno Hideaki's *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–1997). The last is closest. Its Human Instrumentality Project would dissolve all individual boundaries into a single sea of primordial fluid, and its protagonist finally refuses it, choosing separated and painful existence. The Ascian Rejoining and Sephiroth's Reunion are instrumentality projects; the series' heroes, like Shinji, prefer a sundered and plural world.

Arthur C. Clarke supplies two further terms. In *Childhood's End* (1953) humanity's children merge into a cosmic Overmind and the Earth is consumed in the transition: transcendence by

merger as apocalypse, the plot the Ascians and Sephiroth propose and the series refuses. And Clarke's third law, that any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic (1973), names the series' refusal to separate the two. Magitek, machina and materia are technologies of the sacred, and the critique of one is the critique of the other.

7.5 ◆ Feuerbach's Primals

FF XIV makes the projection theory of religion literal. Its primals are summoned from aether by the fervent prayer of the desperate; once manifest, they "temper" their worshippers, binding their wills. Feuerbach argued that God is the alienated projection of the human species-essence (*The Essence of Christianity*, 1841); Marx called religion "the sigh of the oppressed creature" and "the opium of the people" (1844); Durkheim found the origin of the sacred in the collective effervescence of assembled groups (1912). Borges's Tlön, where objects called *hrönir* are produced by expectation (1940), supplies the fantastic precedent. The primals of the beast tribes are gods born of displacement and fear; tempering is alienation made visible.

Heavensward (2015) turns the analysis upon the "civilized." Ishgard's thousand-year war against the dragons is revealed to rest upon a lie: its founding king and his knights slew the dragon Ratatoskr and consumed her eyes for power, then concealed the crime in sacred history. The structure recalls Plato's noble lie (*Republic* 414b–415d) and Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913), in which society is founded on a primal murder whose guilt is ritually disguised. The Archbishop's final transformation into a primal completes the critique: the church becomes the god it projected. *Endwalker* then reveals that Zodiark and Hydaelyn, the twin gods of the world, were themselves primals summoned by the Ancients. Every god in Eorzea is made. What remains is the question of what a god who knows she is made should do.

7.6 ◆ The Kenotic God

Endwalker answers with a theology of self-limitation. Hydaelyn, it emerges, was the Ancient Venat, who became a primal to oppose Zodiark, sundered the world to weaken him, and guided its peoples for millennia toward the moment when they could face the Final Days without her. In a last trial she tests whether they can stand alone; satisfied, she gives her blessing and fades. Paul describes Christ as having "emptied himself" (*ekenōsen*, Philippians 2:7); Isaac Luria's doctrine of *tzimtzum*, transmitted by his disciples in the sixteenth century and expounded by Gershom Scholem (1941), describes God's contraction to make room for creation; Simone Weil spoke of creation as divine abdication and of our task as "decreation" (1947). Dietrich Bonhoeffer, imprisoned by the Nazi regime for his part in the resistance and executed at Flossenbürg in April 1945, wrote from his cell that God lets himself be pushed out of the world, and that before God and with God we live without God (1944). Hans Jonas, whose mother was murdered at Auschwitz, asked after the Nazi genocide of Europe's Jews what concept of God remained possi-

ble, and answered with a God who had renounced omnipotence in creating and entrusted the world's fate to its creatures (1984). Hydaelyn is that God.

The *Kosmoskampf* therefore reaches its mature form not in the killing of the god but in the god's self-sending. *Endwalker* holds both possibilities together. Zodiark, the god who would preserve the old world, is slain; Hydaelyn, the god who lets go, sends herself. The series' theology ends where its ethics begins: the highest divinity is the one that consents to pass.

7.7 ◆ An Iconology of Summoned Gods

ENTRY · ENGLISH TERM · JAPANESE TERM · CONNOTATION

FF VI **Espers** 幻獣 (*genjū*) *Phantom beasts; drained for power*	FF VIII **Guardian Forces** G.F. *Militarized protection paid for in memory*
FF IX **Eidolons** 召喚獣 (*shōkanjū*) *Greek eidōlon: phantom, image*	FF X **Aeons** 召喚獣; the Fayth are 祈り子 (*inorigo*) *Greek aiōn; Valentinian emanation; "prayer-children"*
FF XIII **Eidolons** 召喚獣 *Phantoms answering despair*	FF XIV **Primals** 蛮神 (*banshin*) *"Barbarian gods"; projections of prayer*
FF XV **Astrals** 六神 ("the Six") *Ancient patron gods; designers of fate*	FF XVI **Eikons** 召喚獣 *Greek eikōn: likeness, icon, bound to a Dominant*

TABLE 3. *A lexicon of summoned powers.*

The vocabulary of the series' summoned beings constitutes an implicit iconology. Plato distinguished in the *Sophist* (235d–236c) between *eikastikē*, the making of likenesses that preserve the proportions of their originals, and *phantastikē*, the making of appearances that only seem to; the English lexicon maps that distinction onto the series' gods, from phantoms (*eidōla*) to icons bound to human bodies (*eikones*).

FF XVI is accordingly an iconoclastic eschatology. Byzantium fought for more than a century (726–787; 815–843) over whether images of the holy might be venerated; John of Damascus defended icons on the ground that the honor paid to an image passes to its prototype, and the Second Council of Nicaea (787) agreed. Clive's destruction of the Mothercrystals and of the power behind the Eikons ends magic altogether, accomplishing what Max Weber called the disenchantment of the world (*Entzauberung der Welt*, 1917/1919) and presenting it as emancipation rather than loss. The epilogue, in which children of a later, magicless age turn the pages of a book bearing the series' own title and attributed to Joshua Rosfield, shows what survives disenchantment: not the icon but the story. *Lightning Returns* had ended similarly, its heroine arriving in a world that resembles our own. In both, the fantasy passes from cult into memory, from magic into literature.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Monomyth without Return

Psychopompic Heroism and the Polyphonic Party

The protagonist of *Final Fantasy* is not, in the decisive cases, a hero of return. This chapter shows how the series deforms Campbell's monomyth, identifies its true heroic archetype in the psychopomp, and locates the subject of its ethics in the party rather than the individual.

8.1 ◆ Campbell and the Missing Return

Joseph Campbell's monomyth (*The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, 1949) describes a cycle of departure, initiation and return, in which the hero recrosses the threshold bearing a boon and becomes "master of the two worlds"; it extends the morphologies of Otto Rank (1909) and Lord Raglan (1936) and was codified for screenwriters by Christopher Vogler (1992). The series honors the first two stages and repeatedly withholds the third. Tidus dissolves. Noctis dies on his throne. Zack dies within sight of Midgar. Aerith dies in the Forgotten Capital. Lightning departs for another world. Clive's fate is left on a shoreline. Squall returns from compressed time only because another finds him. Cloud returns, but haunted, and *Advent Children* exists to finish his return. The one unambiguous homecoming, Zidane's, occurs on a stage, during a performance of the play *I Want to Be Your Canary*: return is granted, but as theater. The monomyth's circle is lithic, the closed loop of Eliade's archetypal return; the series' heroic line runs to an end.

8.2 ◆ Cecil and the Shadow

FF IV (1991) retains the most Campbellian structure and the most Christian vocabulary. On Mount Ordeals the dark knight Cecil confronts a mirror-image of his former self and can prevail only by refusing to strike it. Jung's account of the shadow—the repressed counter-self that must

be integrated rather than destroyed (*Aion*, 1951)—describes the scene closely, as does the Daoist *wu wei*, action through non-action. Cecil becomes a paladin through non-violence toward his own darkness. His brother Golbez is the shadow externalized; Zemus's hatred, surviving its bearer as Zeromus, is the shadow unintegrated, the Unsent within.

8.3 ◆ The Psychopomp

The heroic type the series actually develops is the *psychopomp*, the conductor of souls. Hermes leads the shades of the suitors down to Hades in the last book of the *Odyssey*; Charon ferries the dead; Anubis weighs their hearts; the Valkyries choose the slain. Mircea Eliade identified the shaman as the psychopomp par excellence, the specialist in the journey to the underworld (*Shamanism*, 1951). Japan preserves the type in the *itako*, traditionally blind female mediums of the northeast who, at Mount Osore in Aomori, perform *kuchiyose* (口寄せ), lending their mouths to the dead; in the *miko* of shrine tradition; and, in Okinawa, in the *noro* and *yuta*, female ritual specialists of Ryukyuan religion. Spira's visual design is widely understood to draw on Okinawa and Southeast Asia, and its summoners are shamans in Eliade's precise sense. Yuna's pilgrimage proceeds through initiatory ordeals (the Cloisters of Trials), acquires spirit-helpers (the aeons) at temples, descends to a city of the dead and performs the Sending. Rydia, in *FF IV*, journeys to the realm of summoned beings, where time runs differently, and returns grown. Garnet, in *FF IX*, inherits the lineage of a destroyed summoners' village. Lunafreya, in *FF XV*, is the Oracle who communes with the gods and draws the plague from the sick. Aerith, the last of the Cetra, hears the Planet and prays for Holy. The Warrior of Light of *FF XIV*, whose Echo grants sight into the memories of souls, repeatedly accompanies the dead to their rest.

Psychopompic heroism, as defined here, is the heroism whose telos is to conduct passage: to escort others, and finally oneself, to completion. It differs from Campbell's in two respects. Its boon is not brought back but given away. Its terminus is not return but a threshold the psychopomp may cross and not recross.

8.4 ◆ The Polyphonic Party

Mikhail Bakhtin described Dostoevsky's novels as polyphonic, composed of a plurality of independent and unmerged voices with equal rights (1929; rev. 1963). *FF VI* (1994) is the series' polyphonic masterpiece: fourteen playable characters, no single protagonist, a world broken at the midpoint and a party reassembled one voice at a time. *FF IX* and the Scions of *FF XIV* extend the form. Watsuji's *aidagara* supplies its ethics: the subject of action is the between. Camus's "we exist" supplies its politics. Le Guin's "Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986), which opposes to the "killer story" of the lone hero's spear the container that holds many things, describes even the genre's furniture: the party and the inventory are carrier bags.

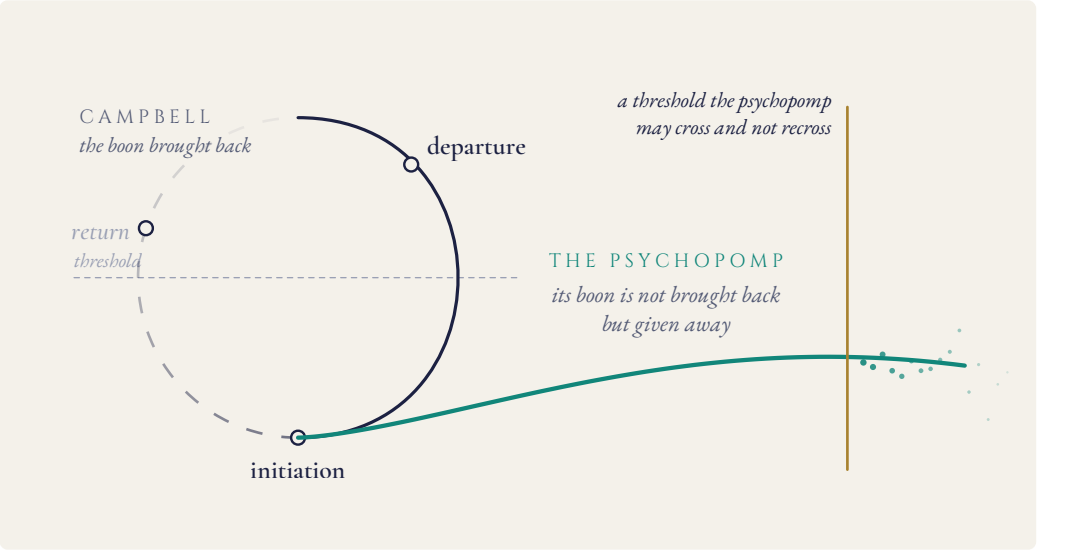


FIGURE 9 *The monomyth without return. The series honors departure and initiation and withholds the third stage; the psychopomp's line runs to a threshold it does not recross (§§8.1, 8.3).*

FF IX gives the ethic a maxim. Zidane's question—in the Japanese, 誰かを助けるのに理由がいるかい？, "Do you need a reason to help someone?"—recurs as the game's refrain and states, in a thief's idiom, Levinas's claim that responsibility for the other precedes any justification of it. The party is the community of those who help without first asking why.

The battle systems encode this ethic. The Active Time Battle system, designed by Itō Hiroyuki for *FF IV*, distributes time among actors without a single sovereign rhythm, a temporal polyphony. The Limit Breaks of *FF VII* and the Trance of *FF IX* are triggered by damage sustained, converting suffering into capacity—a *pathic* mechanic in which vulnerability becomes power. The party is the anti-crystal. The crystal repeats a single unit; the party holds unlike voices together without merging them. It is the formal refutation of every instrumentality.

8.5 ◆ Love as Anti-Crystalline

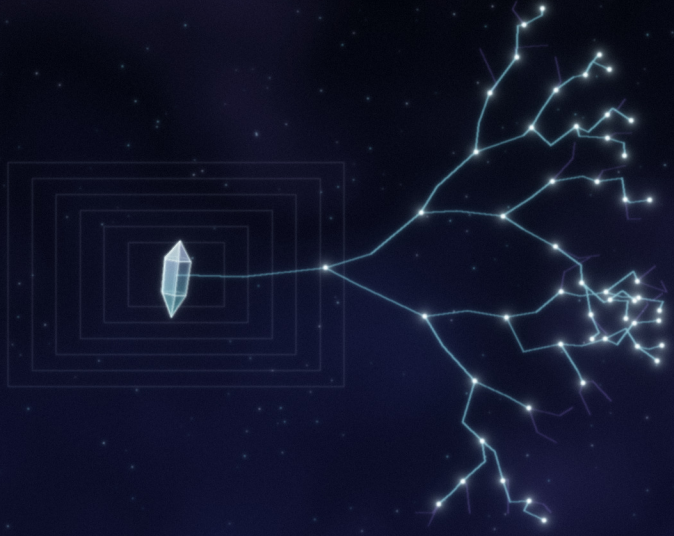
The series' love stories share a structure: love that consents to loss. At the end of *FF VIII*, Squall, lost in compressed time, finds that he can no longer recall Rinoa's face; he is saved when she finds him in the flower field where they had promised to meet. Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) argued that the face of the Other breaks every totality and opens onto the infinite. Ultimecia's compressed time, in which all moments are gathered into one, is totality; Rinoa's face, lost to memory and restored by her arrival, is infinity. Levinas's title describes the game's finale exactly. Alain Badiou defines love as fidelity to an event and as the construction of a world from the point of view of two (2009); the promise to meet in the flower field is such an event.

At the end of *FF X*, Yuna runs to Tidus as he fades and passes through him. In the English text she declares her love; in the Japanese original, as is often noted, her parting word is one of gratitude. The divergence is philosophically material. Gratitude is the grammar of sending, the word one speaks to the departing. Love in the series is defined against the love of the Unsent—Sphene's love that keeps her dead, Emet-Selch's that rebuilds his city, Caius's that would stop time for Yeul. The series distinguishes love that keeps from love that lets go, and honors only the second.

8.6 ◆ The Sacrificial Feminine and Its Critique

The series has repeatedly placed women in the position of sacrifice. Aerith dies; Yuna is designated to die; Lunafreya spends her life; Fang and Vanille become the pillar of Cocoon, a *hitobashira* of the kind Japanese legend sets in the foundations of castles and bridges; Ovelia, in *Tactics*, is a pawn of crowns; Serah is crystallized; Yeul dies with every vision; Rinoa is sealed away as a dangerous sorceress; Jill is enslaved as a Dominant. The comparative archive is ancient—Kushinadahime in the *Kojiki*, Andromeda, Iphigenia. Feminist theory supplies the critique. Barbara Creed's "monstrous-feminine" (1993) names the horror attached to maternal power, embodied in Jenova, whom Sephiroth calls Mother. Silvia Federici's history of the witch-hunts (2004) illuminates *FF VIII*'s sorceresses, feared, hunted and sealed, and Rinoa's dread of becoming one. Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection (1980) explains the expulsion of the feminine body from the symbolic order.

The series also dismantles the pattern. Yuna refuses the Final Summoning. *X-2* gives its women the narrative, though in an idiom of pop-idol performance and costume change that Butler's theory of performativity can read both as liberation and as commodity. Lightning makes the theomachist a woman. Jill is freed and acts. Venat makes the kenotic god female. The critique must nonetheless be pressed: the series sometimes abolishes the sacrifice of women by transferring it to men, as Tidus and Noctis inherit the position Yuna refused. The fully anti-sacrificial ethic is reached only where sacrifice gives way to sending: consent to one's own passage, never designation for another's ends.



CHAPTER NINE

Autotheomachy

The Player as Unsent God

The series' gods are, in a strong sense, images of the apparatus by which its worlds are played. This chapter reads the ludic apparatus as a metaphysics, the antagonists as figures of that apparatus, the series' metafiction as its self-consciousness and the *Remake* as its crisis, and concludes by defining *autotheomachy*: the reflexive deicide in which the player is enlisted against the figure of the player.

9.1 ◆ The Ludic Apparatus as Metaphysics

Huizinga located play within a "magic circle" set apart from ordinary life (1938); Caillois classified games by competition, chance, simulation and vertigo (1958); Juul described games as "half-real," real rules joined to fictional worlds (2005); Galloway defined the video game as a medium of "gamic action" (2006). The Japanese role-playing game descends from *Dungeons & Dragons* (1974) through *Wizardry* and *Ultima* (both 1981) to *Dragon Quest* (1986) and *Final Fantasy*. Within its apparatus the player holds powers over time that no character possesses: to save, to reload, to reset, to revive. The series' status effects form a compressed metaphysics of those powers. *Stone* lithifies; *Stop* arrests time; *Doom* imposes a countdown to death, a ludic *memento mori*; *Zombie* inverts healing, so that cures harm; *Reraise* or *Auto-Life* grants pre-emptive resurrection, an Unsent condition cast as a blessing. The Phoenix Down (in Japanese, the phoenix's tail) is the most telling: it revives the fallen and, in many entries, instantly destroys the undead. It is a *pharmakon* in Derrida's sense, remedy and poison at once, and its double action is the Sending in miniature: what restores the living releases the Unsent.

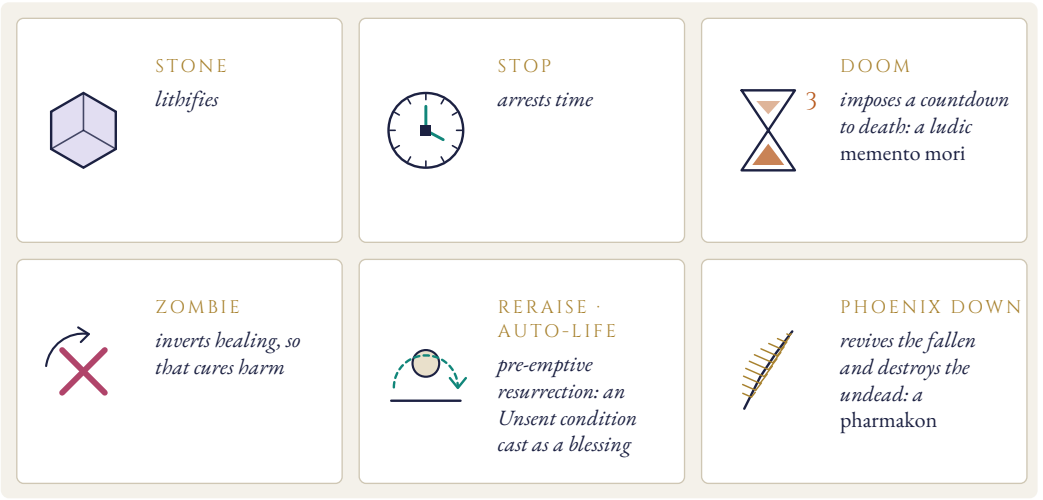


FIGURE 10 *The status effects as a compressed metaphysics of the player's powers over time (§9.1).*

9.2 ◆ Antagonists as Figures of the Apparatus

Read against the apparatus, the Communion of the Unsent acquires a second meaning. Garland's loop is the reset. Ultimecia's compression, in which all moments are co-present, is the save file. *Type-0*'s iterated cycles, staged again and again by a hidden experimenter in search of a desired outcome, are the reload. Caius's paradoxes, and the alternate "paradox endings" of *XIII-2*, are branching save states. Yu Yevon's dream is the runtime, a world that exists only while it is run, and the Fayth who dream it are structurally its players. Ultima, who names Clive "Mythos" and seeks to inhabit him as a vessel, is the player's desire for an avatar. The *Remake*'s Whispers are the canonical script defending itself; the *Remake*'s Sephiroth, the only figure who seems to know how the 1997 story ends, is the returning player's foreknowledge. Kefka, who rewrites the map of his world, is the designer as god. No claim of authorial intention is made. The claim is structural: the series' images of illegitimate divinity coincide, point by point, with the powers its medium confers upon those who play it.

9.3 ◆ Metafiction and the Stage

FF IX opens with a performance. The Tantalus troupe stages *I Want to Be Your Canary*, by the playwright Lord Avon—a transparent homage to the Bard of Avon—as cover for an abduction, and the game's first heroics take place on a stage. Shakespeare's "All the world's a stage" (*As You Like It* II.vii) and the play within the play of *Hamlet* (III.ii) are the obvious precedents; Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921) and Unamuno's *Niebla* (1914), whose protagonist confronts his author to plead against his own death, are the modern ones. Balthier in *FF XII* repeatedly casts himself as the story's "leading man," a character who knows the rules of character. *FF X* is narrated by Tidus in retrospect, beginning with his request that the listener

hear his story; Auron tells him at the outset that this is his story; the game's structure is the telling of a tale that ends with its teller's dissolution. In the *Remake*, the party confronts the arbiters of the original script and, in the final chapter, at what the game calls Destiny's Crossroads, defeats their embodiment, the Whisper Harbinger. That is Unamuno's revolt carried through.

FIGURE 11 *The apparatus and its gods: the series' images of illegitimate divinity set against the powers its medium confers on those who play it (§9.2).*

Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler* (1979), addressed to its reader in the second person, supplies the postmodern term. Tidus's request to be heard, spoken to the player before the story begins, makes the player the listener whose attention completes the tale.

9.4 ◆ The Remake: Sengū or Revenant

Walter Benjamin argued that technical reproduction detaches the work from the "aura" of its unique existence in time and place (1935–36). The *Remake* poses the question of the aura from within: is it a reproduction of the 1997 original, a replacement for it, or something else? Japan offers a third model. Since the late seventh century, with interruptions, the shrines of Ise have been rebuilt every twenty years on an adjacent site in new cypress, in the rite of *shikinen sengū*; the sixty-second rebuilding took place in 2013. Authenticity at Ise resides not in the material but in the form of renewal; the Ship of Theseus (Plutarch, *Theseus* 23), a puzzle in the West, is a liturgy there. Deleuze argued that true repetition produces difference, and read Nietzsche's eternal return as the return not of the same but of difference (1962; 1968). Nietzsche's demon asks

whether one would will one's life again, every moment in the same order (*The Gay Science* §341, 1882). The *Remake* asks a generation of players that question about a game. The Whispers answer that it must return the same: Eliade's archaic repetition. The party answers that it may return, but differently: Deleuze's. The Harbinger's defeat is the *ikai-okuri* of the 1997 text, the original sent so that the remake may live.

The *Remake*'s branching has both a literary and a physical genealogy. Borges's "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941) imagines a novel in which every alternative is taken at once, so that time forks perpetually; Hugh Everett's relative-state formulation of quantum mechanics (1957), popularized as the many-worlds interpretation, gives the image the standing of physics. The trilogy uses both: in a world adjacent to the canonical one, Zack Fair survives his last stand. The Whispers are the gardeners who prune the forks; the party is the fork that grows.

Rebirth (2024) brings the trilogy to the threshold of the Forgotten Capital and stages Aerith's death in doubled form. Whether the conclusion performs a *sengū*—renewal that honors the death it repeats—or a revenant's return—refusal of the death the original made sacred—is the question on which the series' ethics now turns.

A precedent exists within the franchise. *Final Fantasy XIV*, launched in 2010 to a poor reception, was ended within its own fiction: in 2012 its world was overwhelmed by the descent of the lesser moon Dalamud and the dragon Bahamut, and in 2013 it was reborn as *A Realm Reborn*, set five years after that Calamity. The game narrated its own commercial death as an apocalypse and its relaunch as a rebirth. It is the most literal instance of the series sending itself.

9.5 ◆ Autotheomachy Defined

Autotheomachy designates the reflexive deicide in which a work reveals its gods as figures of the apparatus by which it is played and enlists the player—holder of that apparatus—to defeat them. The player wields lithic sovereignty: saving, reloading, reviving. The narrative condemns that sovereignty wherever it appears as godhood. The player defeats the gods by means of that very sovereignty, and then the credits arrive: the world ends, and the player must let it end. *FF X* is the paradigm. When Yu Yevon falls, the Fayth stop dreaming, and Tidus, through whom the player has inhabited Spira, fades. The player's own presence in the world is the dream that must end, and the game closes by sending its player. *FF XVI* is the most recent form. Ultima's craving for a vessel mirrors the player's inhabitation of Clive; Clive's refusal to be possessed, and the open ending in which his fate is withheld, emancipate the vessel from its inhabitant.

Miguel Sicart's argument that players are moral agents whose play constitutes ethical practice (2009) gives the concept its stakes: autotheomachy is a practice in which the player rehearses the renunciation of power over time. Other games have gone further in form. *Nier: Automata* (2017) asks the player, in its final ending, to delete their own save data to help unknown others; *Undertale* (2015) remembers the player's resets and holds the player accountable for them. *Final Fantasy* is less radical in form and more sustained in time: across a generation it has made the renunciation of the player's divinity the recurring culmination of play.

9.6 ◆ Ludic Finitude

Games, on this account, are technologies for rehearsing mortality under conditions of reversibility. Their characteristic temptation is to abolish finitude; their characteristic possibility is to make reversibility itself an object of critique. The series' central formal achievement is to realize that possibility: to build worlds in which everything can be undone, and then to teach, within them, the value of what cannot.

PART FIVE

Synthesis

CHAPTER TEN

The Sending as First Philosophy

CHAPTER TEN

The Sending as First Philosophy

Toward an Ethics of Passage

The preceding chapters converge on a single position. This chapter formalizes it as *fluvial finitism*, or the ethics of passage, after accounting for the series' seriality and its temporality, and then tests it against objections.

10.1 ◆ Recapitulation

The argument can be stated as a sequence. The series' cosmology opposes crystal and stream and discovers the crystal to be arrested stream (Chapter One). Its antagonists are the Unsent, who refuse passage and institute necrostasis (Chapter Two), sustained by necro-extractivism (Chapter Three) and enforced by empires behind which stand gods (Chapter Four). Its persons are constituted by promise rather than retention, and by death shared rather than death owned (Chapters Five and Six). Its theology moves from *Chaoskampf* to *Kosmoskampf* and culminates in kenosis (Chapter Seven). Its heroes are psychopomps who form a polyphonic party (Chapter Eight). Its form enlists the player against the player's own divinity (Chapter Nine). Two structures remain to be described: the series' seriality and its temporality.

10.2 ◆ The Ālayic Franchise

Each numbered entry builds a new world, yet certain names migrate. Cid has been an airship engineer (*IV*), an imperial scientist (*VI*), a pilot who dreams of space (*VII*), a Garden headmaster (*VIII*), a regent transformed into an insect (*IX*), a thunder-god knight (Cidolfus Orlandeau, *Tactics*), an Archadian scientist in league with a renegade god (*XII*), a brigadier turned l'Cie (Cid Raines, *XIII*), an Eorzean engineer (Cid nan Garlond, *XIV*), a Lucian mechanic (Cid Sophiar, *XV*) and a rebel who shelters slaves (Cidolfus Telamon, *XVI*). Biggs and Wedge recur as soldiers

and comrades; chocobos and moogles (from *mogura*, mole, and *kōmori*, bat) recur as fauna; Bahamut, Shiva, Ifrit, Odin, Leviathan and Alexander recur as powers; the crystal recurs as the cosmos's ambiguous heart. No Cid is the same Cid. Names transmigrate; selves do not.

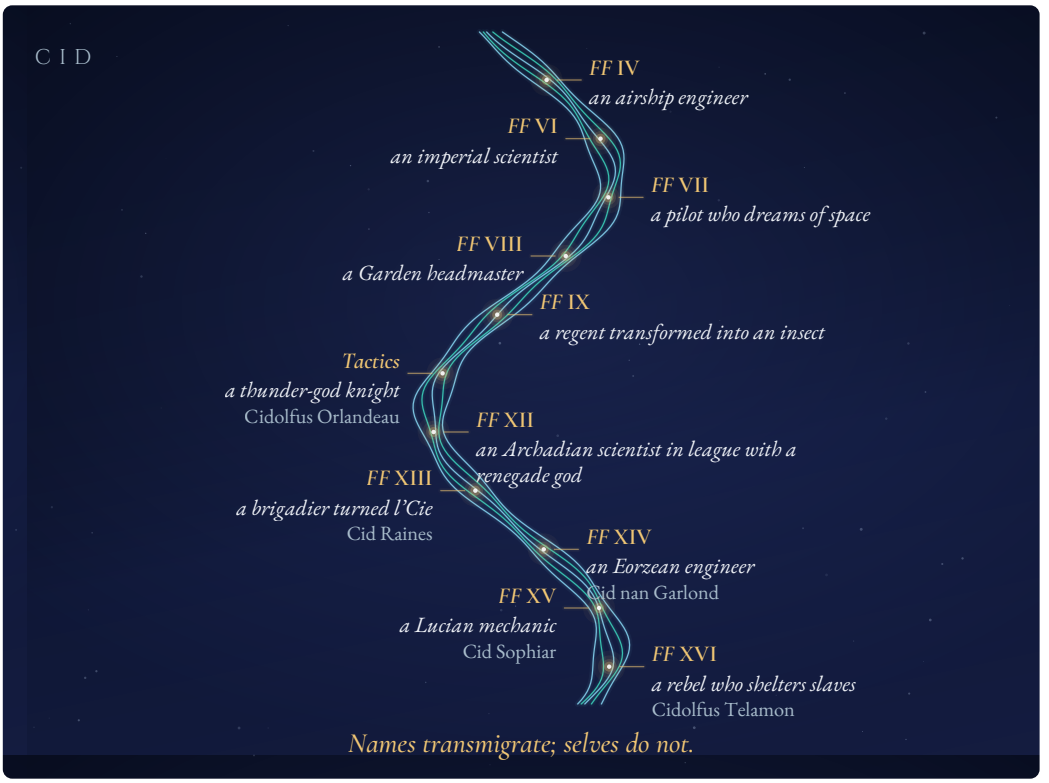


FIGURE 12 *The ālayic franchise: eleven Cids, one name and no shared self (§10.2).*

Two Japanese theories have addressed such seriality. Ōtsuka Eiji adapted the Kabuki dyad of *sekai*, a known world such as the revenge of the Soga brothers, and *shukō*, the variation each new production brings, into a theory of narrative consumption (1989). *Final Fantasy* inverts the dyad: the world is new each time, and the variations persist. Azuma Hiroki's database model (2001) describes the consumption of detachable elements without a grand narrative. It fits the franchise's surface but misses its depth, for a database is lithic: elements are stored unchanged and retrieved identical.

The more exact model is the Yogācāra *ālayavijñāna*, the storehouse-consciousness systematized by Asaṅga and Vasubandhu. The storehouse holds seeds (*bīja*) deposited by past action through a process called perfuming (*vāsanā*); seeds ripen into new manifestations; and the storehouse is not a self, since, as the *Triṃśikā* says, it proceeds like a torrent. The franchise is ālayic in exactly this sense. Each entry perfumes the store, and its seeds ripen, transformed, in later worlds: the Lifestream of *VII* in the pyreflies of *X* and the aetherial sea of *XIV*; Rydia's shamanic journey in *IV* in Yuna's pilgrimage; the Magitek extraction of *VI* in the Bearers of *XVI*. The storehouse is

fluvial. Michael Moorcock's Eternal Champion, the one hero reborn in many forms across a multiverse (1970)—a genealogy documented through Amano's illustrations—is its Western counterpart; and *Dissidia Final Fantasy* (2008), which gathers heroes from many entries into a cyclical war between Cosmos and Chaos in which they forget between cycles, makes the storehouse playable.

One figure guards the doctrine by mocking its opposite. Gilgamesh, flung into the Interdimensional Rift at the end of his appearance in *FF V*, resurfaces in later worlds, implied to be the same wanderer, collecting legendary swords and, as often as not, a counterfeit Excalibur. He bears the name of literature's first seeker of immortality and is the only self the series allows to persist across incarnations. He is a comic figure. The series' judgment on the ego's wish to survive its world is laughter.

10.3 ◆ Three Temporalities

The series distinguishes three temporalities. The first is *lithic eternity*, the *nunc stans*. Boethius defined eternity as the whole, simultaneous and perfect possession of interminable life—*interminabilis vitae tota simul et perfecta possessio* (*Consolation of Philosophy* V.6, c. 524). Ultimecia's time compression is a creature's attempt to seize that divine simultaneity; Faust's arrested moment and the crystal are its images. The second is *cyclical recurrence*: Eliade's archaic time, Spira's Sin, Garland's loop, the iterations of *Type-0*, the Ascians' Rejoinings. The third is *passage*: the river of Heraclitus and of Chōmei, Dōgen's being-time, Whitehead's perpetual perishing, and the sensibility Motoori Norinaga named *mono no aware* (物の哀れ), the pathos of things in their passing (1763). The series' ethics occupies the third. It rejects eternity as tyranny and recurrence as terror, and locates value in the completion of what passes.

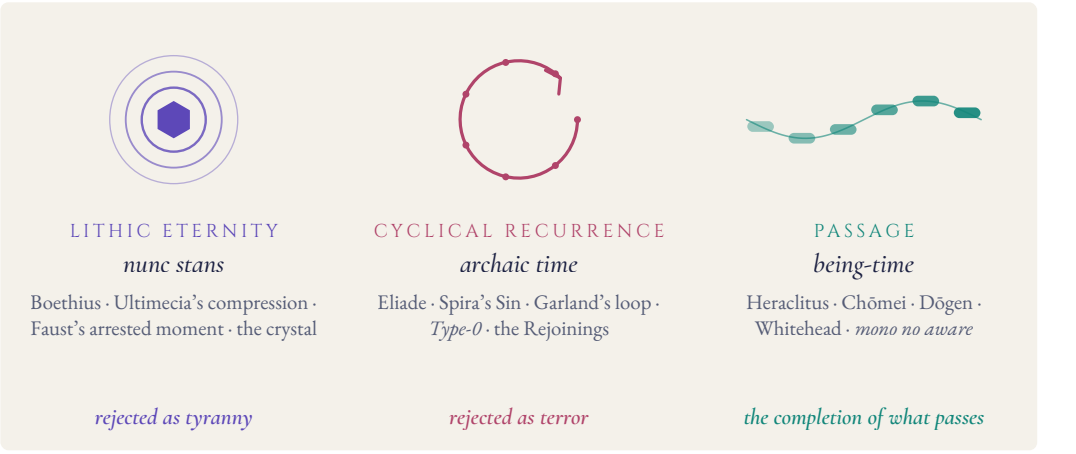
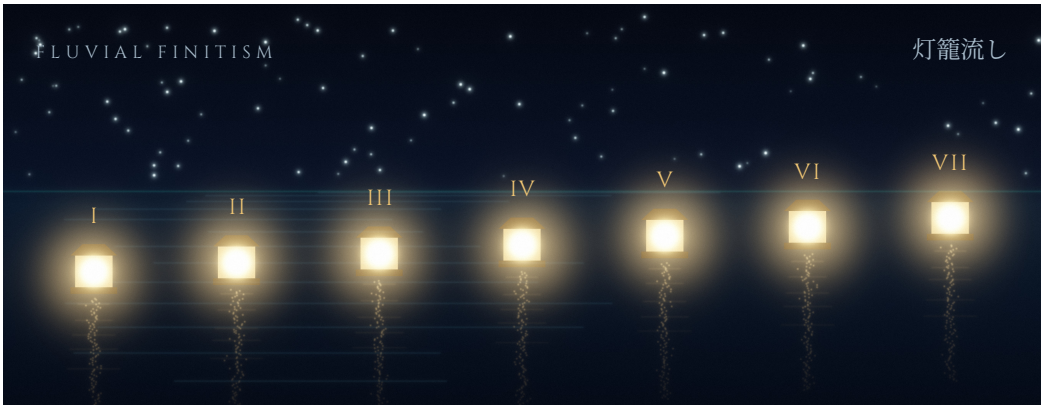


FIGURE 13 *Three temporalities. The series' ethics occupies the third (§10.3).*

10.4 ◆ The Ethics of Passage

Fluvial finitism may be stated in seven theses.



I The first is the axiom of completion. Nothing that lives is wronged by its ending; it is wronged by being prevented from ending well. The Unsent, and the institutions built upon them, commit this wrong.

II The second is the prohibition of necrostasis. The dead are neither to rule nor to be used, neither hoarded nor harvested. Every economy that runs on the unreleased dead, whether mako, Mist or archived memory, is illegitimate.

III The third is the anti-providential principle, with its kenotic exception. No order that requires the arrest of time—through sacrifice, Focus, fate or canon—commands obedience. Yet the highest divinity is not abolished; it is the one that sends itself.

IV The fourth concerns the self. Identity is constituted not by retained memory but by kept promises and granted forgiveness. Memory's ethical form is therefore remembrance-in-release, memory that completes the Sending rather than replacing it.

V The fifth is the psychopompic vocation. The highest heroism is to conduct passage: to accompany others to their completion and, when the time comes, oneself. Its subject is the party, the between, not the solitary hero.

VI The sixth is the autotheomachic duty. Whoever holds power over time—the player, the franchise, the state, the archive—bears the duty of letting things end.

VII The seventh is that ending is a gift. The end of a world is its consummation, not its failure. The credits are the world's dharma-position, as the ash is the firewood's.

10.5 ◆ Objections and Replies

First objection: cultural essentialism. The reading may be accused of discovering a timeless Japanese spirit in a commercial product—the self-Orientalism Iwabuchi criticized, or the techno-Orientalism analyzed by Morley and Robins (1995). **REPLY:** no essence is claimed. The thesis identifies a transcultural syncretism in which a European fantasy surface—castles, knights, Norse names, Christian vocabulary—is articulated through a Japanese religious grammar of mortuary rite, spirit pacification and shrine renewal. The "odorless" export, in Iwabuchi's term, is odorless only to noses untrained in incense.

Second objection: the commercial contradiction. A franchise of remakes, remasters, re-releases and an online world designed to run indefinitely practices the very necrostasis it condemns. **REPLY:** the contradiction is real and constitutive, and the series has already supplied its figure. Auron, in *FF X*, is Unsent: dead for ten years, he remains among the living only to guide the young, and when his work is done he consents to be sent. The franchise is legitimate on its own terms only so long as it is Auron, an Unsent that remains to guide and consents to go. *X-2*'s restoration of Tidus is the first instance of the franchise's temptation to un-send; the conclusion of the *Remake* will be the decisive one.

Third objection: the aestheticization of death. The ethics of passage leans on Motoori Norinaga's *mono no aware*, and that inheritance is compromised. Emiko Ohnuki-Tierney has shown how the Japanese military state converted the aesthetics of transience, above all the falling cherry blossom, into an injunction to die for the emperor (2002). The conversion was literal. When the Imperial Japanese Navy organized its first special-attack (*tokkōtai*) unit in the Philippines in October 1944, under Vice Admiral Ōnishi Takijirō, its four sections were named from a single waka by Motoori—Shikishima, Yamato, Asahi and Yamazakura—the verse that likens the Japanese spirit to mountain cherry blossoms fragrant in the morning sun. Over the following ten months the Navy and the Army sent several thousand young pilots, many of them conscripted university students, to their deaths crashing aircraft into Allied ships, and state propaganda praised those deaths as falling blossoms. The philosophers on whom this thesis draws were implicated too. Heidegger joined the National Socialist party in 1933 and served as rector at Freiburg. Schmitt joined the same year and in 1934 defended the killings Hitler ordered in the Night of the Long Knives ("Der Führer schützt das Recht"). Members of the Kyoto School, Nishitani among them, framed the Pacific War as world-historical in published round-table discussions of 1941–1942, and Nishitani was barred from teaching under the Occupation. Watsuji's wartime essays on reverence for the emperor put his ethics of betweenness at the service of the imperial state. An ethics of passage assembled from these sources could become an ideology of sacrificial death.

REPLY: the series distinguishes passage from death designated by the collective, and condemns the latter consistently. It refuses the child soldiers of *Type-0* their beautiful deaths, exposes the Final Summoning as a lie, frees the Bearers and indicts the Gardens. The criterion that sepa-

rates the two is the one this thesis has applied throughout: consent against designation, release against use. The *tokkōtai* pilot was designated by the state, and his death was converted into propaganda that governed the living—necrostasis and necro-extractivism in historical form. The Sending refuses both; it releases the dead from instrumentalization rather than producing them. In this precise sense the series is an anti-*tokkōtai* text, and its sources must be read against their authors' politics. Watsuji's betweenness is used here against the state's claim on death, not for it, and Motoori's pathos of passing things is honored only where nothing is made to pass for a cause.

Fourth objection: determinism. The heroes often fulfill the destinies they protest; Noctis dies as foretold. **REPLY:** the freedom the series honors is the freedom of consent. Spinoza identified freedom with the adequate understanding of necessity (*Ethics*, 1677); Nietzsche called its affective form *amor fati*; Dōgen located it in the full occupation of one's position in time. The decisive act is not to escape the end but to own it, together with others.

Fifth objection: gendered sacrifice. The series long placed women in the sacrificial position. **REPLY:** the objection is sustained in part (Chapter Eight). The ethics of passage formulated here is a critique of that tradition drawn from the series' own resources: designation for death is necrostasis; consent to passage is its opposite.

10.6 ◆ Coda: The Book Called *Final Fantasy*

Several of the series' endings are images of what survives a world. *FF VII* shows Midgar overgrown after five centuries. *FF X* sends its aeons and its dream. *Lightning Returns* sets its heroine down in a world like ours. *FF XVI* closes on children of a later, magicless age and a book bearing the series' own title, attributed to Joshua Rosfield. What survives is not the crystal, the icon or the Unsent, but the story. That is the only immortality the series grants: not the subjective immortality of the self that refuses to pass, but the objective immortality of the tale that is received. Tidus's first words in *FF X* ask the listener to hear his story.

The title can now be read as a formula. *Final Fantasy* names a fantasy *of* finality, an imagination of ending, and a fantasy that consents to *be* final, a work that lets itself end. The last fantasy is the one that agrees to close.

Conclusion

This thesis has argued that *Final Fantasy* is a philosophical system whose first philosophy is the Sending. Its contributions may be gathered under six headings.

To game studies it offers the concepts of *autotheomachy* and *ludic finitude*, a reading of status effects and revival mechanics as a compressed metaphysics, and a resolution of the much-discussed dissonance between the Phoenix Down and Aerith's death as an argument rather than an error. To the philosophy of religion it offers the distinction between *Chaoskampf* and *Kosmoskampf*, a reading of the series' theology as inverted Gnosticism, and an account of its culmination in a kenotic deity, in conversation with Luria, Weil, Bonhoeffer and Jonas. To the environmental humanities it offers *necro-extractivism*, a concept that joins the critique of extraction to the critique of necropolitics and may prove useful beyond its occasion. To memory studies it offers a typology of three regimes—crystalline amnesia, crystalline hypermnesia and fluvial anamnesis—and a promissory theory of the self developed from Ricoeur and Arendt. To Japanese studies it offers *ikai-okuri*, the *goryō* cult, the *itako*, the *hitobashira* and the *shikinen sengū* as hermeneutic keys, and an ālayic account of seriality as an alternative to the database model. To comparative literature it situates the series within a speculative literature of refused death that extends from Gilgamesh to Le Guin and Jemisin.

The study has limits. Its corpus closes in 2024, before the conclusion of the *Remake* project and before later narratives of *Final Fantasy XIV*. It relies, for several entries, on localized texts, though it treats localization as interpretation. And it constructs a system from the work of many hands, which requires a methodological caveat. After Barthes's death of the author (1967) and Foucault's author-function (1969), the "system" described here is a hermeneutic object, not a

claim about any designer's plan; its unity is that of a tradition in Gadamer's sense rather than of an intention. The series' author-function is *Final Fantasy* itself.

Several avenues follow. The conclusion of the *Remake* trilogy will confirm or refute the ethics this thesis attributes to the series. Comparative study of *Dragon Quest*'s preserved *Chaoskampf*, of the god-slaying of *Xenoblade Chronicles* (2010) and of the ludic sacrifice of *Nier: Automata* would situate the *Kosmoskampf* within Japanese games more broadly. Reception study—above all of the collective mourning that followed Aerith's death in 1997—could test empirically whether play rehearses grief. And a ludo-theology that took seriously the claim that games are rituals might begin from the Sending.

If the series has a single teaching, it is that a world is not betrayed by its ending but by the refusal to let it end; and that the highest work of the living—of heroes, of gods, and of those who play them—is to send.

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KEYWORDS

Final Fantasy; Square Enix; philosophy of video games; game studies; Japanese role-playing games; *ikai-okuri* (the Sending); necrostasis; necro-extractivism; theomachy; *Chaoskampf*; *Kosmoskampf*; autotheomachy; ludic finitude; metempsychotic seriality; *ālayavijñāna*; Yogācāra; Dōgen; Kyoto School; Watsuji Tetsurō; Nishitani Keiji; being-toward-death; finitude; mortality; personal identity; quasi-memory; narrative identity; memory studies; hauntology; political theology; biopolitics; necropolitics; ecocriticism; extractivism; Gaia; Gnosticism; kenosis; *tzimtzum*; iconoclasm; disenchantment; psychopomp; shamanism; monomyth; polyphony; *mono no aware*; *goryō*; *shikinen sengū*; *hitobashira*; comparative mythology; speculative fiction; Tolkien; Le Guin; *Final Fantasy VII Remake*; *Final Fantasy X*; *Final Fantasy XIV*.